

Title of review

Methods for reporting online sexual harassment

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I. BACKGROUND

The rise of online sexual harassment in recent years has spurred discussions both within the European Union and internationally. To effectively address this issue, it is imperative to foster collaboration among various sectors, including government entities, non-governmental organizations, educational institutions, media outlets, and technology companies. These sectors collectively develop and implement practical intervention strategies to systematically support individuals affected by online sexual harassment. Notably, social media platforms play a crucial role in addressing this issue. These platforms have implemented measures such as automated content detection and flagging systems, allowing users to report harmful content to moderators. Nevertheless, these measures, on their own, have been proven to be inadequate given the personalized nature of online harassment, which is influenced by factors such as culture, sex, gender, sexual orientation and, generally, the intersectionality of various systems of oppression.

Hence, the development of effective user self-reporting systems is imperative. These systems should provide victims¹ with immediate assistance during harassment incidents, promoting a safer online environment, while also enhancing user trust and overall platform satisfaction. The objective of this report is to provide decision-makers both from political

¹ The authors acknowledge the ongoing debate about the use of the word “victim” as it may be interpreted to mean that those targeted are in a passive state of subjugation. The authors acknowledge also the growing advocacy, especially by members of the civil society, for the use of the word “survivor” as it emphasizes the strength of the people targeted by sexual harassment. However, the authors also note the debated about how this emphasis on strength may burden the targeted community with the obligation to overcome such traumatic experiences. Hence, the utilization of the expression “victims” in this report should be interpreted through this critical lens.

bodies and from online platforms with preliminary evidence-based innovative ideas on how to improve the user self-reporting system on social media platforms. Testing the effectiveness of the proposed reporting systems is part of our ongoing research.

2. MAIN OBJECTIVES

This report aims to:

- 1) Provide insights from international surveys about what are the prevalent online sexual harassment behaviors, on which social media platforms users experience those behaviors, which groups within the population are potential victims, and the victims' reporting experiences ;
- 2) Present an overview of the legal framework at the European Council and European Union that defines online sexual harassment and that prescribes the corporate human rights responsibilities to counter online sexual harassment;
- 3) Provide concrete examples of user self-reporting procedures on prominent social media platforms, including Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter. Additionally, explore user feedback on these reporting systems;
- 4) Analyze the strengths and weaknesses of the user reporting systems;
- 5) Present conclusive recommendations for enhancing the design of reporting systems;
- 6) Provide evidence-based victim personas and prototypes of innovative user self-reporting systems.

3. HIGHLIGHTS

a) Section 5 presents an overview of **factors that may deter users from reporting incidents on social media platforms**, categorized into two main groups:

1) Platform-related factors:

- Insufficient or hard-to-access information on which online sexual harassment behaviors can be reported.
- Lack of clear communication about how user reports are handled.
- Complex and confusing reporting procedures.
- Unclear reporting categories.
- Low visibility of the reporting feature.
- Delayed or unhelpful responses to user reports.
- Lack of human interaction or response.

2) Personal factors:

- Users' desire to move on from the issue.
- Belief that the problem is too trivial to report.
- Feelings of embarrassment or shame.
- Doubt that the reporting will yield the desired outcomes.

It is important to note that victims of online harassment typically seek a resolution where the harassment stops, the harassers are prevented from continuing their actions, and the harassers are removed from the social media platform.

b) In Section 6, we present a set of **evaluation criteria** specifically designed to **assess reporting systems aimed at combating online sexual harassment**. These criteria are

based on the legal framework established at the European Council and European Union levels, as well as the usability standards outlined in the International Organization for Standardization (ISO) framework. We provide an in-depth examination of the current user self-reporting processes on Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter, accompanied by a critical evaluation of their system designs. Additionally, we analyze the Transparency Centers of these platforms and offer **recommendations to enhance their transparency reports**. Moving on to Section 6, we provide a concise overview of the **strengths and weaknesses observed in the current self-reporting systems** of Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter. We also share **insights derived from a co-design workshop** we conducted with interdisciplinary experts during the World Anti-Bullying Forum in 2021. Finally, in conclusion, we put forward innovative ideas for improving the existing reporting systems on social media platforms, including the presentation of example prototypes.

Notably, this report was compiled without the involvement of social media platform representatives. We welcome feedback and suggestions for corrections, which can be directed to the first author, Yuying Tan, at Yuying.Tan@uantwerpen.be.

4. TERMINOLOGY

The term “online sexual harassment” is defined in Section 5.1 and the distinction between this term and “cyberbullying, sexism, online hate speech” is explained in Section 5.2. In this report, we also use other terms which are not clarified in detail in further sections but which, based on existing literature, are briefly explained as follows:

Image-based sexual abuse – Includes two key behaviors: a) sexting coercion or engaging in unwanted sexual behavior via sexually explicit pictures or video, b) creation, distribution or threat of distribution of sexually explicit images of another person without their consent. (Henry & Witt, 2021; Powell et al., 2022; The Economist, 2021; Victims’ Commissioner, 2022). Some relevant terms include: creepshots (sexually suggestive or private pictures taken without consent and shared online), upskirting (sexual or private pictures taken under the skirt or dress without consent and shared online), revenge porn, deepfakes, and happy slapping (either live-streamed or distributed on pornographic sites).

Online harassment – Repeated behavior using textual or graphical content to frighten and undermine self-esteem or reputation. Abusive and insulting language, purposeful embarrassment and shaming (Barak, 2005; Craig et al., 2020; Plan International, 2020; Powell et al., 2020, 2020; The Economist, 2021).

Trolling – Posting inflammatory, insincere, digressive, extraneous, or off-topic messages in an online community, with the intent of provoking readers into displaying emotional responses, or manipulating others' perception (Glitch, 2020; Victims’ Commissioner, 2022).

Defamation – Spreading rumors and slanders to discredit or damage a woman’s character (The Economist, 2021).

Cyber flashing – Similar to online harassment, but it is special for its delivery channel, sending an unsolicited obscene sexual image via AirDrop or Bluetooth (Victims' Commissioner, 2022).

Cyberstalking – Tracking someone's location using GPS or social media, and the use of Remote Access Tools (RATs) to spy on a computer from afar (The Economist, 2021; Victims' Commissioner, 2022).

Doxing – Searching publicly available databases and social media websites and unauthorized retrieving and publishing of an individual's personal information (The Economist, 2021).

Violent threats – Threats of offline violence, rape threats, injury or death threats, etc. directed at the victim and/or their offspring and relatives, or incitement to physical violence (Plan International, 2020; The Economist, 2021; Victims' Commissioner, 2022).

Grooming – Befriending and establishing an emotional connection with the target with the objective of sexual abuse (Victims' Commissioner, 2022).

When these terms are related to a victim's perceived gender or sexual orientation, or when the aggression towards a victim is sexually oriented in nature, it is categorized as online sexual harassment. All the surveys cited in this report are public online. All surveys, data, graphs that we use in this report can be found in our OSF open science project ².

Women – This report adopts an inclusive definition of “women” by including in the use of this expression both cisgender and transgender women, except when referring to literature

² OSF project - Methods to report online sexual harassment:
https://osf.io/me59f/?view_only=1d3668750aa44bcd9c95aeceafed85d3

or empirical research which departed from this definition. This report acknowledges the understudy of the oppression of the transwomen community and the scholarship alerting to the fact that transwomen are a community highly targeted by online sexual harassment (Craig et al., 2020; Powell et al., 2020; Powell & Henry, 2019). For this reason, whenever possible this report will reflect on this critical approach to gender studies.

5. INTRODUCTION

5.1 What is online sexual harassment?

5.1.1 The conceptualization from social sciences

Sexual harassment is a prevalent phenomenon which typically happened during face-to-face social environments. Originally, Till (1980) classified sexual harassment behaviors into five categories: 1) sexist remarks or behavior; 2) inappropriate and offensive, but sanction-free sexual advances; 3) solicitation of sexual activity by promise of rewards; 4) coercion of sexual activity by threat of punishment; 5) sexual crimes and misdemeanors) (Till, 1980). Later, following a series of studies, the suggestion was made to change the classification of types of SH into three distinct categories: gender harassment, unwanted sexual attention, and sexual coercion (Fitzgerald et al., 1995).

With rapid expansion of social media platforms, alt-tech platforms, and other new ICT technologies (virtual reality, deepfake, social bots), sexual harassment nowadays also happens in digital spaces. Online sexual harassment occurs on a variety of digital platforms: mostly social media and their countless features and spaces, but also on web pages and forums, search engines, messaging apps, blogs, dating websites and apps, media comment

sections, chat rooms of online video games, streaming platforms, video game apps, virtual and augmented reality tools, chat apps, videoconferencing tools, professional apps and websites (Van der Wilk, 2021).

Barak (2005) extended the definition of sexual harassment to online sexual harassment, giving an explicit theoretical definition of the three types in the online context. Forms of online sexual harassment include and are not limited to the following (Barak, 2005):

1. Online gender harassment, including offensive or denigrating comments made about the targets' sexuality or sexual orientation, homophobic comments, LGBTQ+ degradation comments, slut-shaming, victim-blaming, teasing about appearance and body related to sexuality or sexual orientation; embarrassing jokes, sexual objectification, sexual rumors, ratings related to sex life, reinforcing gender stereotypes.
2. Unwanted sexual attention, including sexual materials about oneself being shared without consent, being asked for sexual materials unwillingly, unwanted exposure to online sexual materials, hyper-intimacy messages such as excessive disclosure and redundant messages of affection. The sexual materials include sexually explicit messages, images, videos, or other types of content including body parts like a penis, dick, pussy, nasty, sexual, nude pictures, (revenge) porn, talk about sex, masturbation, experience in bed, role play.
3. Online sexual coercion, such as forced sexting, sextortion, rape threats, cyberstalking, and incitement to commit rape.

5.1.2 The legal conceptualization from human rights

From a legal perspective, technology-facilitated violence against women includes the following categories:

1. **“Online sexual harassment** (including cyber flashing – or sending unsolicited sexual images – sexualised comments, sexualised defamation, sexualised slander, impersonation for sexual purposes and doxing, as well as sexualised and gender-based trolling, flaming, mob attacks), image-based sexual harassment such as creepshots (sexually suggestive or private pictures taken without consent and shared online), upskirting (sexual or private pictures taken under the skirt or dress without consent and shared online), image-based sexual abuse (non-consensual image or video sharing, or non-consensual intimate image (NCII) or “revenge porn”), deepfakes, recorded sexual assault and rape, including “happy slapping”(either live-streamed or distributed on pornographic sites), threats and coercion such as forced sexting, sextortion, rape threats, incitement to commit rape;
2. **Forms of online stalking**, surveilling or spying on social media or messaging, password stealing, cracking or hacking devices, spyware installation, impersonation for stalking means, tracking via GPS or geolocation, scaring, threatening and controlling via smart locks or smart home appliances;
3. **Forms of psychological violence** such as online sexist hate speech and incitement to self-harm or suicide, verbal attacks, insults, death threats, pressure, blackmail, deadnaming (revealing someone’s former name against their wishes for the purposes of harm).” (Van der Wilk, 2021).

Articles 33, 34 and 40 of the Council of Europe Convention on preventing and combating violence against women and domestic violence, also known as the Istanbul Convention (Council of Europe, 2011) are the basis for the legal framework of the herewith presented legal approach to the conceptualization of online sexual harassment (Van der Wilk, 2021). The Istanbul Convention is crucial to protect the rights of women and the LGBTQ+ community. The Istanbul Convention came into force on 1 August 2014 and, to date, it was ratified by 36 States and the European Union. As of March 2019, it has been signed by 45 countries and the EU. Although, the Istanbul Convention does not contain an explicit reference to online sexual harassment, several of its articles are applicable in the digital context. For example, the scope of this Convention as prescribed in Art.2 extends to violence committed in the digital space and the scope of sexual harassment as defined in Art.40 and of stalking as defined in Art.34 also apply to online and technology-facilitated acts.

In addition to the Istanbul Convention, the legal framework addressing online sexual harassment is complemented by Articles 2, 3, 8 and 10 of the Council of Europe Convention on Cybercrime, also known as the Budapest Convention (Council of Europe, 2001). The Budapest Convention clarifies the responsibilities of States and businesses to counter online sexual harassment and it is further explained in section 5.8.1. of this report.

5.2 Differences between online sexual harassment and online hate speech, sexism or cyberbullying

Some types of online sexual harassment may overlap with online hate speech, sexism, cyberbullying. These latter terms can be clarified as follows:

Online hate speech is a type of speech that takes place online with the purpose of attacking a person or a group based on their race, religion, ethnic origin, sexual orientation, disability, and/or gender (Johnson et al., 2019). Online hate speech is not easily defined, but can be recognized by the degrading or dehumanizing function it serves (Gagliardone et al., 2015). The first type of online sexual harassment - online gender harassment can be seen as one kind of online hate speech because it dehumanizes the sexual orientation or gender identity of a person or group. But the other two types of online sexual harassment – unwanted sexual attention and sexual coercion - are different from online hate speech.

Sexism is prejudice or discrimination based on one's sex or gender. It has been linked to stereotypes and gender roles, and may include the belief that one sex or gender is intrinsically superior to another. In March 2019, the Committee of Ministers of the Council of Europe adopted a new recommendation on preventing and combating sexism that contains the first internationally agreed definition of sexism, including online and via emerging technologies (e.g., robots, smart devices) (Council of Europe Committee of Ministers, 2019).

Sexism is defined as:

“Any act, gesture, visual representation, spoken or written words, practice or behavior based upon the idea that a person or a group of persons is inferior because of their sex,

which occurs in the public or private sphere, whether online or offline, with the purpose or effect of:

- *I. violating the inherent dignity or rights of a person or a group of persons; or*
- *II. resulting in physical, sexual, psychological or socio-economic harm or suffering to a person or a group of persons; or*
- *III. creating an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment; or*
- *IV. constituting a barrier to the autonomy and full realization of human rights by a person or a group of persons; or*
- *V. maintaining and reinforcing gender stereotypes."*

Comparing online sexual harassment with sexism as defined above, the first type of online sexual harassment – gender harassment – overlaps with sexism because gender harassment may violate the inherent dignity of a person or a group, it may create a hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment, it may also be a form to maintain and reinforce gender stereotypes (e.g., girls cannot learn math well, females cannot handle programming). The other two types of online sexual harassment – unwanted sexual attention and sexual coercion, overlap with sexism because they can both create an intimidating environment. Similar to what is defined as sexism, online sexual harassment may also violate the inherent dignity or rights of a person or a group, for example, gender or sexual orientation based humiliating messages can harm the dignity of people or a group. Online sexual harassment may also result in physical, psychological or socio-economic harm or suffering to a person or a group. For example, cyberstalking may cause the feeling of fear or threatening to victims and may also bring safety problems to victims in real life. Spreading sexual rumors about a

person online may cause reputation problems to the victim. Spreading rumors about LGBTQ+ persons may mislead the public's opinion towards them, disadvantage them as a group of people being discriminated in society.

Cyberbullying has been defined as an aggressive act or behavior that is carried out using electronic means by a group or an individual repeatedly and over time against a victim who cannot easily defend him or herself (Slonje et al., 2013). Cyberbullying has mostly been studied as a form of peer aggression amongst young people, and is often intertwined with traditional (offline) bullying. Cyberbullying behaviors can take many different forms. Perpetrators can, for instance, engage in direct forms of cyberbullying (directly aimed at the victim, such as sending someone insults or threats) or in indirect forms of cyberbullying (behind the back of the victim, such as creating a hate group about a person). They may use different types of messages (e.g., verbal messages, emojis, pictures, and videos), different communication (plat)forms (e.g., e-mail, instant messaging, social networking sites, and games), and different devices (e.g., mobile phones, computers, and gaming consoles) to harass victims in a private or public way, with or without revealing their own identity. Online sexual harassment and cyberbullying are not clearly differentiated in the scientific literature, in particular, definitions of cyberbullying often include behaviors that constitute online sexual harassment (e.g., sending unwanted sexual content, asking someone to do something sexual) (Copp et al., 2021). When forms of cyberbullying are related to victims' (perceived) gender or sexual orientation, or when the content of the repeated aggression towards a victim with less power is sexually in nature, there is an overlap with online sexual harassment.

5.3 Prevalence of online sexual harassment

The Economist Intelligence Unit (EIU) completed a study in 2020, measuring the global prevalence of online sexual harassment against women (The Economist, 2021). Over 4500 women aged above 18 participated in the EIU survey. In their survey, prevalence was measured at three levels: personal, community, and overall or witnessed. At a personal level, 38% of the women reported personal experiences with online sexual harassment. At a community level, 65% of the women reported knowing other women who had been targeted online from their personal and professional networks. At an overall level, 85% of the women reported witnessing online sexual harassment against other women (including those from outside their networks) in the last 12 months. According to a scientific study amongst a US-based sample of adolescents ($n = 1,152$, 10-18 years old), nearly 15% reported online sexual harassment experiences (Copp et al., 2021). In an India based sample ($n = 291$, 21-32 years old), 56.5% women and 43.5% men said that they received uncomfortable online sexual harassment messages (Nova et al., 2019). In a Swedish-based sample of adolescents ($n = 594$, 12-20 years old), 9.26% of the girls and 5.73% of the boys had been called a fag or pussy against their will, or someone had been commenting on their private life in a sexual manner in the last six month (Ståhl & Denhag, 2021). In a Chilean-based sample of adolescents ($n = 18,872$, 12 -17 years old), 16.23% reported being online sexual harassed (Guerra et al., 2021). In a Spanish-based sample of adolescents ($n = 3,897$, 12 - 17 years old), online sexual victimization (sexual coercion, sexual pressure, online grooming by an adult, unwanted exposure to sexual content and violation of privacy) was reported by 39.5% of the

participants (Montiel et al., 2016). In German-based sample (n = 9,000, 10 – 50 years old) 68.3% reported having experienced online sexual harassment (receiving pornographic material or being asked intimate questions) (Henry & Powell, 2018). In a Dutch-based sample (n = 1,026, 18 – 88 years old), 4.6% of the men and 6.7% of the women had been sexually solicited online (receiving unwanted requests to talk about sex or do something sexual) in the past 6 months, and 5.6% of male adolescents and 19.1% of female adolescents had been sexually solicited online in the past 6 months (Baumgartner et al., 2010).

Online sexual harassment can have aversive outcomes for victims. Victims experience emotional stress and outcomes such as lower self-esteem and self-confidence after being exposed to online harassment (Johnson, 2017).

5.4 Prevalent forms of online sexual harassment behaviors

The EUI survey (2021) with 4500 respondents above the age of 18, revealed that 67% of the women reported witnessing defamation in the last 12 months (including spreading fake or exaggerated news through rumors or falsehoods that aim to discredit women, and in particular public figures (for example, public officials, activists, journalists)). 66% of the women reported witnessing online harassment in the last 12 months. 65% of the women reported witnessing hate speech to attack or humiliate against other female victims in the last 12 months (including all forms of expression that spread, incite, promote or justify racial or religious hatred, xenophobia, often also targeting gender/sexual orientation or other forms of hatred based on intolerance towards women). 63% of the women reported witnessing cyberstalking of other women in the last 12 months (including intercepting

communications and data, and may involve stealing passwords, tracking someone's location using GPS or social media, and the use of Remote Access Tools (RATs) to spy on a computer from afar). 58% of the women reported witnessing astroturfing against other women in the last 12 months (a coordinated effort to concurrently share damaging content across platforms). 57% of the women reported witnessing image-based abuse towards other women in the last 12 months (including two key behaviors: a. sexting coercion or engaging in unwanted sexual behavior via sexually explicit pictures or video, b. the creation, distribution or threat of distribution of sexually explicit images of another person without their consent). 55% of the women reported witnessing doxing against other women in the last 12 months (including the unauthorized retrieving and publishing of an individual's personal information). 52% of the women reported witnessing violent threats towards other women in the last 12 months (including threats of offline violence, rape threats, injury or death threats, etc. directed at the victim and/or their offspring and relatives, or incitement to physical violence) (The Economist, 2021).

According to the results from another survey by Plan International (2020) which investigated the online sexual harassment among 14,000 girls aged 15-25 in 22 countries, the most common type of online sexual harassment behavior is online harassment - abusive and insulting language, reported by 59% of the girls who have been harassed, followed by online harassment -purposeful embarrassment (41%), online harassment - body shaming and violence threat (both 39%) (Plan International, 2020).

A survey from Glitch (2022) covering 484 women and non-binary individuals above the age of 18 in the UK shows that the most common type of online sexual harassment

behaviors include trolling (58%), online harassment (44%), violence threats (21%), cyberstalking (20%), image-based abuse (19%) (Glitch, 2020).

A survey from Victims' Commission (2022) covering 534 women in the UK above the age of 16 shows that the most common type of online sexual harassment behaviors include trolling (36%), cyberstalking (33%), violence threats (24%), cyber flashing (24%), image-based sexual abuse (11%), grooming (8%) (Victims' Commissioner, 2022).

5.5 Popular social media platforms where online sexual harassment takes place

According to the data from DataReportal (2022), the most popular social media platforms worldwide are Facebook, YouTube, WhatsApp, Instagram, TikTok, Facebook Messenger, Snapchat, Telegram, Pinterest, Twitter, Reddit (see Figure 1). On each of those platforms, every month, above 300 million users are active (DataReportal, 2022). With such a huge number of active monthly users, everyday creating and sharing media content, online sexual harassment is very likely to happen. A survey by Plan International (2020) investigated online sexual harassment among 14,000 girls aged 15-25 in 22 countries. Result shows that online sexual harassment is most common on Facebook, where 39% say they have suffered harassment, Instagram (23%), WhatsApp (14%), Snapchat (10%), Twitter (9%) and TikTok (6%) (Plan International, 2020). Another survey by Glitch (2020) captured online sexual harassment experiences of 484 women and non-binary individuals of age above 18 year old in the UK. Their results (see Figure 2) show that on WhatsApp online sexual harassment is more common amongst black and non-binary individuals (21%) than amongst white women

(11%). On other platforms, the prevalence rates are similar. Taking white women as an example, 64% of the respondents who experienced online sexual harassment reported experiencing harassment on Twitter, 25% experienced online sexual harassment on Facebook, 18% on Instagram, 12% on Facebook Messenger, 11% on WhatsApp (Glitch, 2020).

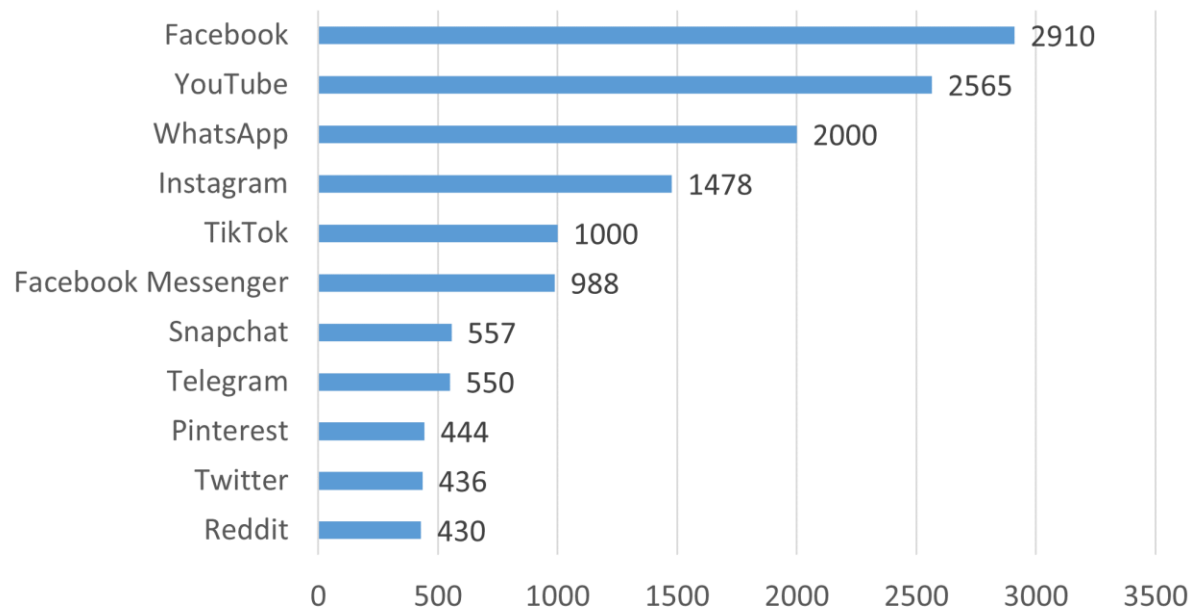


Figure 1 Most popular social networks worldwide as of January 2022, ranked by number of monthly active users (in millions) (Data source: DataReportal (2022))

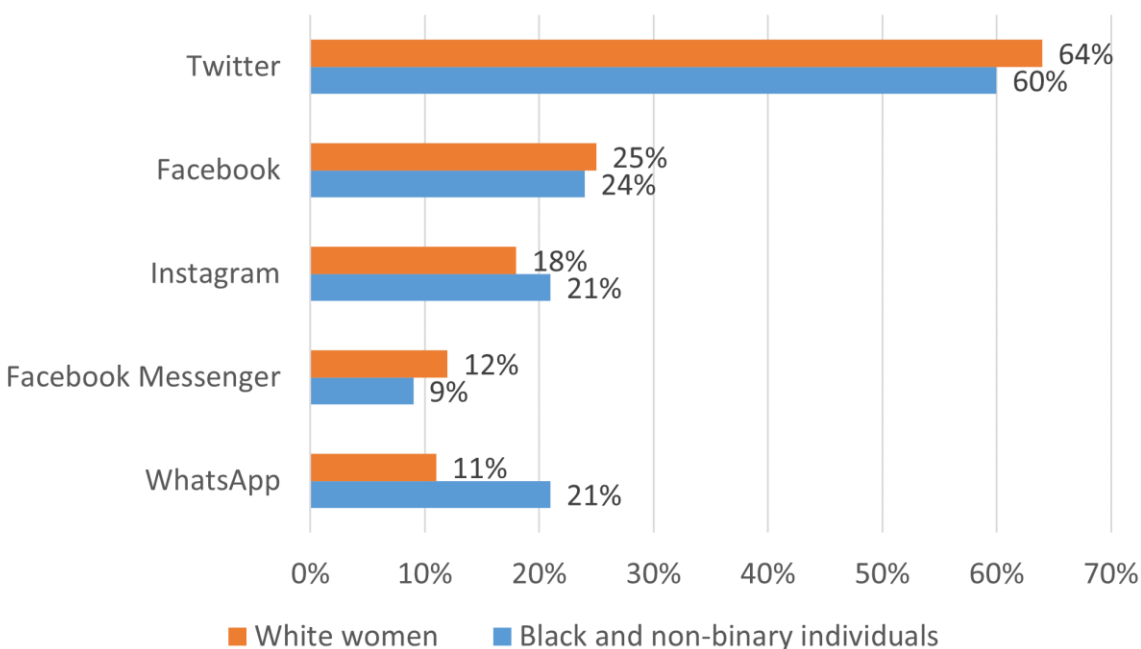


Figure 2 Platforms on which women experienced online sexual harassment, percentage rate represents share of respondents (Source: Glitch (2020))

5.6 Who are the victims of online sexual harassment?

Most studies on people targeted by online sexual harassment regrettably do not seem to adopt a critical approach to the conceptualization of gender (excluding from the survey non-binary and transgender people). In this context, is important to acknowledge that the studies herewith discussed should be read critically and that these do not shed light on the specific lived experiences of non-binary or transgender people. Furthermore, it is important to highlight also the geographical scope of the various studies. Notwithstanding, given the extensive literature (and undebatable at this point in history) on the generalized oppression of women globally, findings can be said to overall represent the lived experience of women regardless of the geographical focus.

A survey conducted in 2022 by the UK Victims' Commissioner shows that almost all types of online sexual harassment experiences are more prevalent among women than men (Figure 3). In this comparison, women are more likely to experience online sexual harassment, grooming, image-based sexual abuse, cyber flashing, cyberstalking, and online harassment. This survey finds that men are more likely to experience online harassment on the basis of their sexual orientation than women. The same survey indicates that, of all age groups, women are more likely to experience image-based abuse than men (Victims' Commissioner, 2022).

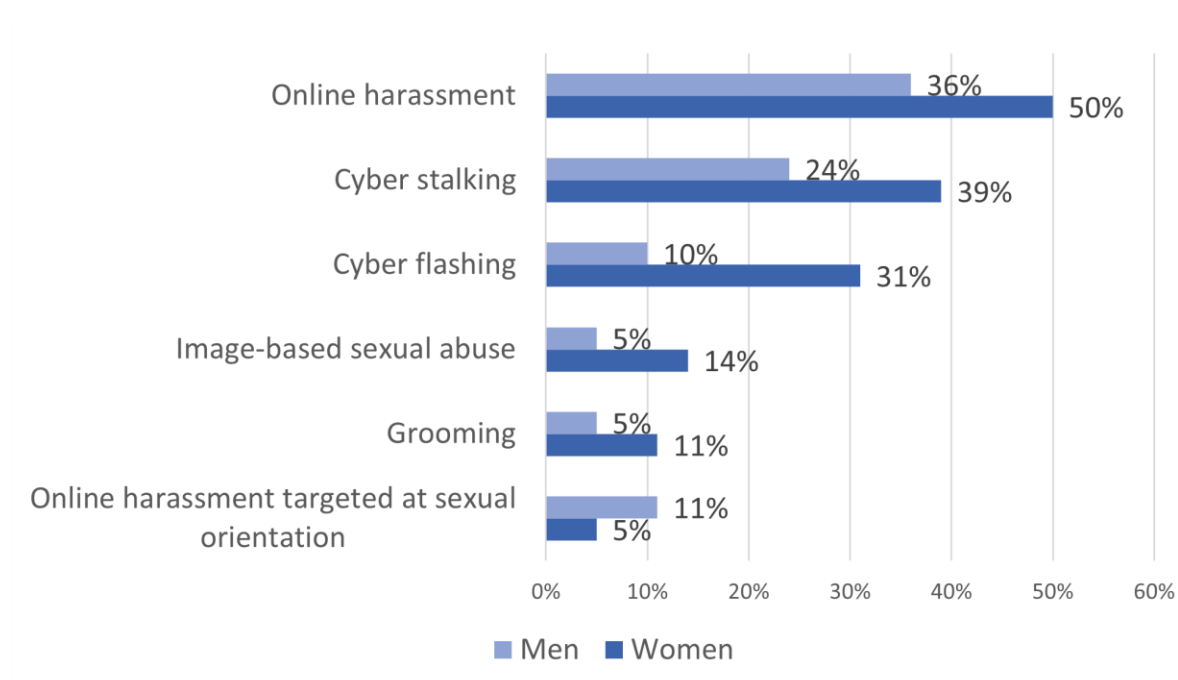


Figure 3. Types of online sexual harassment experienced by victims in UK as of February 2022, by gender, percentage rate represents share of respondents (Source: Victims' Commissioner (2022))

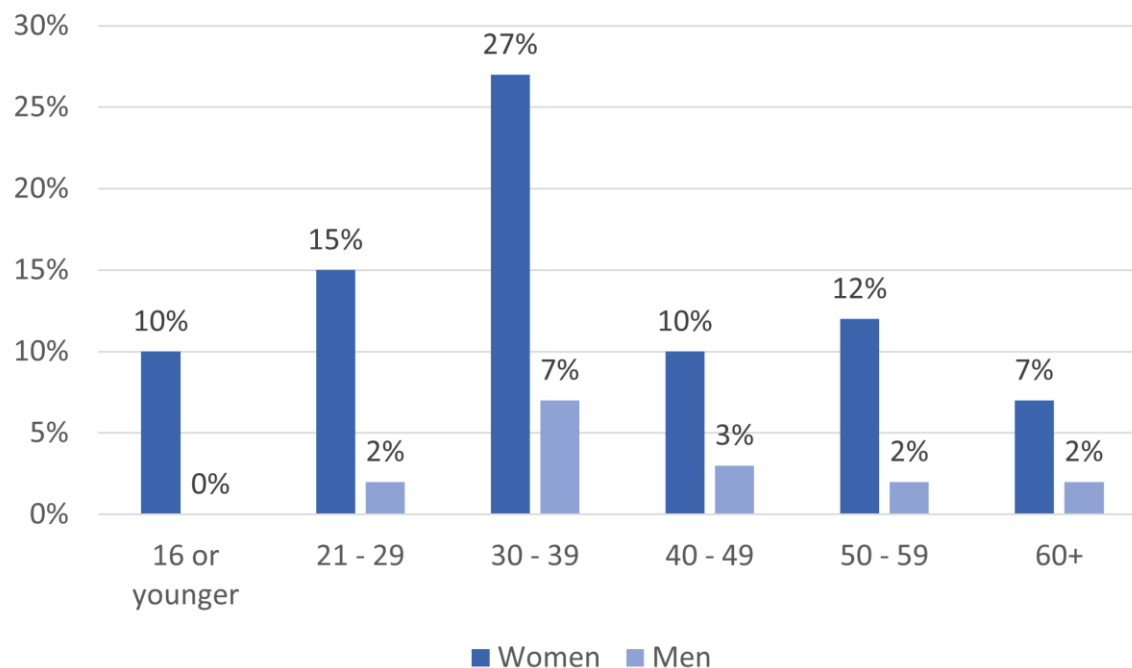


Figure 4. Victims of image-based abuse in UK as of February 2022, by age and gender, percentage rate represents share of respondents (Source: Victims' Commissioner (2022))

Younger women compared to older women are more likely to experience online sexual harassment. The EIU survey (2021) shows that among the online sexual harassment victims, 45% belong to Generation Z or are Millennials (born between 1981-2002), while 31% belong to Generation X or are Baby Boomers (born between 1946-1980) (The Economist, 2021). The results from another survey, as shown in Figure 4, also show that women between the ages of 16-39 are more likely to experience image-based abuse than women above the age of 40.

Besides age differences, there are regional differences in the prevalence of online sexual harassment. According to EIU survey (2021), in the Middle East 98% of the women reported to have witnessed online sexual harassment against other women (including those from outside their networks) in the last 12 months. The percentage in other regions are: 91% in

Latin America and the Caribbean, 90% in Africa, 88% in Asia Pacific, 76% in North America, and 74% in Europe. Based on these data, the EIU survey suggests that women in countries with long-standing or institutionalized gender inequality tend to experience online sexual harassment at higher rates (The Economist, 2021).

Apart from age and regional factors, lesbian, bi, queer and trans women, racialized women and women of color, migrant women, women with disabilities, non-neurotypical woman, etc, are historically more oppressed due to the intersectionality of several systems of systematic marginalization towards these groups. According to the results from a survey conducted by Plan International (2020), more than 56% of those who identify as LGBTIQ+ say they are harassed because of their gender identity or sexual orientation (Plan International, 2020). This argument is supported by another recent survey by Glitch (2020). The survey captured online sexual harassment experiences of 484 women and non-binary individuals above the age of 18 in the UK. Respondents were asked what aspect(s) of their identity the harassment they faced was related to. 21% of the respondents reported suffering from online harassment related to their gender identity and sexual orientation. 7 out of 11 nonbinary respondents experienced online harassment related to gender identity and sexual orientation (Glitch, 2020).

Some of the main findings from the abovementioned studies show:³

³ It is important to reiterate that most studies mentioned in this section regrettably do not seem to adopt a critical approach to the conceptualization of gender (excluding from the survey non-binary and transgender people). In this context, further research is needed to represent the lived experiences of non-binary or transgender people regarding online sexual harassment.

1. Women are more likely to experience online sexual harassment than men.
2. Younger women are more likely to experience online sexual harassment compared to older women.
4. Women in countries with long-standing, systematic or institutionalized gender inequality tend to experience harassment at higher rates.
5. The intersectionality of systems of oppression experienced by e.g. women, queer people, people with disabilities, non-neurotypical people, racialized people, indigenous communities, people of color, etc, exposes them to higher rates of online sexual harassment.
6. Cisgender men are more likely to experience online harassment targeting them on the basis of their sexual orientation.

5.7 Why do victims not report online sexual harassment to social media platforms?

Even though online sexual harassment is prevalent, the actual reporting rate is low. A survey by Childnet (2017) investigated online sexual harassment experiences among young people (13-17 year old) in the EU. Their results show that when facing online sexual harassment, only 39% of the young victims would be likely to report this to the social media platform, 27% would be likely to report it to the police, 15% would be likely to speak to a helpline. As shown in Figure 5, young victims do not report online sexual harassment to social media platforms mainly because they think the platform would not help or do anything (43%), it takes too much effort (18%), they do not know how to report (18%). Instead of reporting to social media

platforms, 82% of the young victims would be likely to choose to block the harassers (Childnet, 2017).

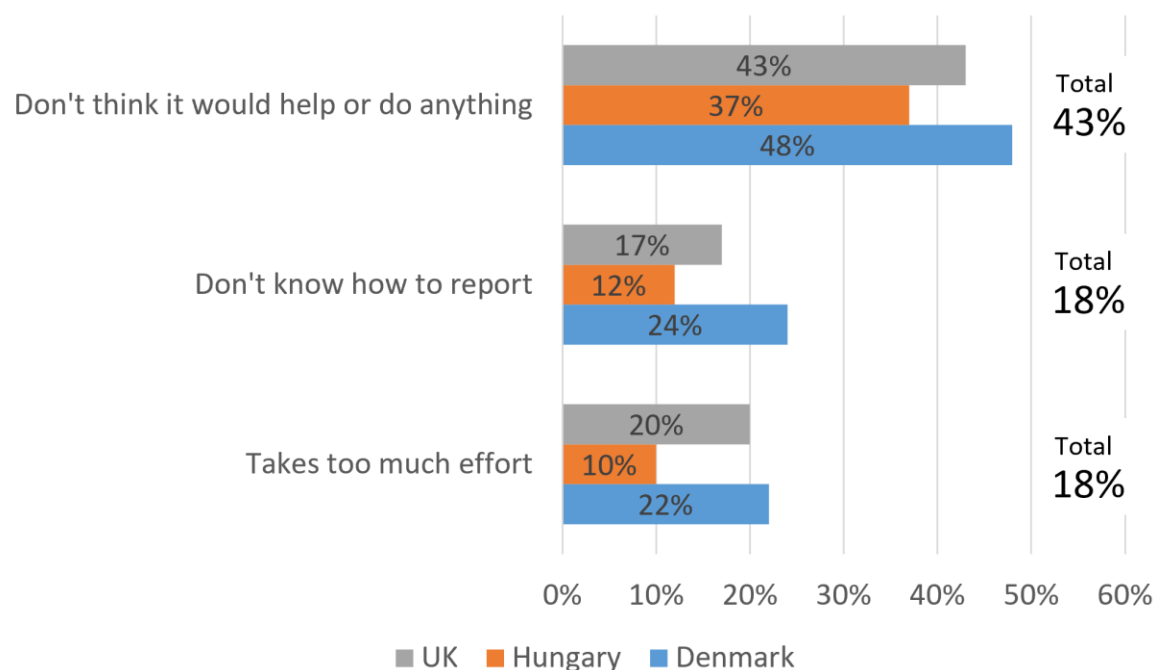


Figure 5. Top reasons for young people to not report online sexual harassment to social media as of 2017 in Denmark, Hungary, UK. Percentage rate represents share of respondents. (Source: Childnet (2017))

The survey results from Childnet in 2017 are very similar to the results of the survey by Victims' Commission (2022), based on the responses of 534 women in the UK. In their survey, only 22% of the victims reported to social media. Among the victims who reported to social media, 65% felt dissatisfied or very dissatisfied with the response they received. Many indicated that they did receive response from social media platforms, but only to be told that their complaints did not breach the company's guidelines. The platform often advice users to block the harasser, but this does not resolve the issue as it is easy for the harasser to quickly make multiple different accounts. Victims in this survey also expressed frustration

about the complaint process and their inability to speak to a person about the harassment. As shown in Figure 6., 83% of the respondents disagreed or strongly disagreed with the statement 'I was able to speak to someone', and 79% disagreed with the statement 'I was given adequate feedback about why no action was taken', 76% agreed that their only method of contacting the internet companies was via a form. Other complaints were: "the platform is not helpful in assisting me" (72%), "the platform does not understand about my concern" (71%), "I was not given adequate feedback about why no action was taken" (71%), "the platform responded slow to my needs" (61%), "the reporting process is not easy to understand" (46%) (Victims' Commissioner, 2022).

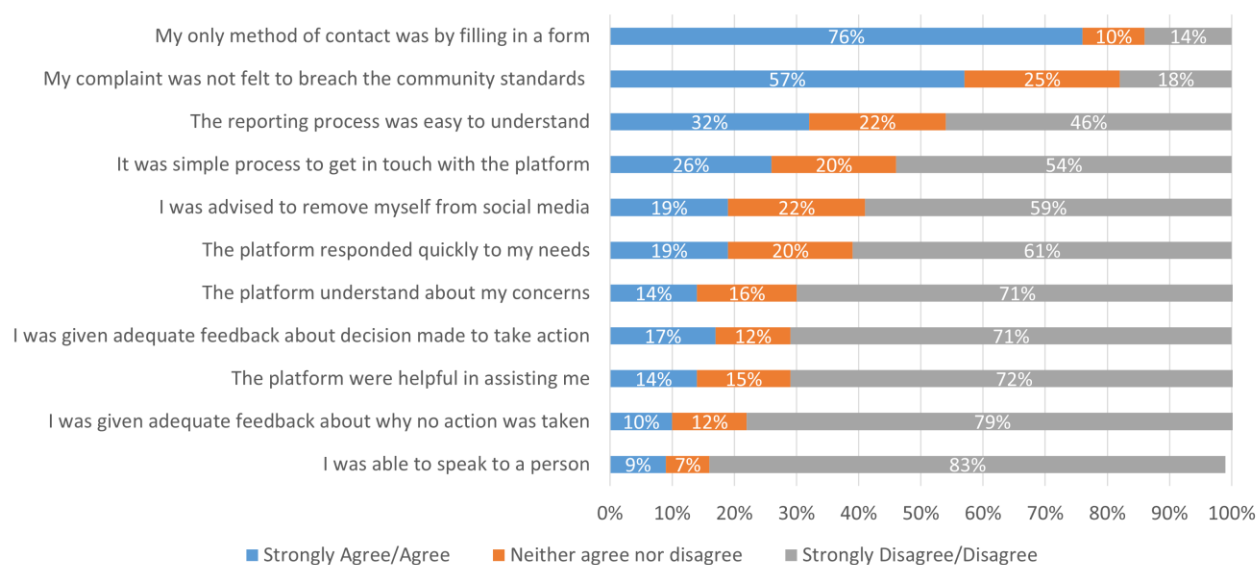


Figure 6. Top complaints about reporting to social media (in the UK in 2022). Percentage rate represents the share of respondents. (Source: Victims' Commissioner (2022))

Among the victims who did not report, the most common reasons were that they just wanted to move on with their lives (39%), felt the problem was too trivial (35%), were embarrassed or shamed about the harassment they were receiving (32%), thought nothing

would come out from the complaint (25%). What victims wanted to happen was that the harassment would stop (48%), the harassers would be prevented from continuing (57%), and the harasser would be removed from social media (44%).

According to the survey by the Economist Intelligence Unit (EIU) (2021) covering women from different regions across the world, aged between 18-74 year old, only 25% of the women reported online sexual harassment to the social media platforms and only 14% of the women reported online sexual harassment to an offline protective agency. 78% of the participants reported that women often do not know that these online sexual harassment behaviors are reportable.

The survey results of Glitch (2020), based on the responses of 484 women and non-binary individuals above the age of 18 in the UK, show a higher rate of reporting. 67% of the victims reported to the social media platforms. But the participants in this survey had similar experiences with the reporting system on social media, saying that replies from social media were often non-existent, unhelpful and too late, in contradiction to the platforms' duty of care towards users (Glitch, 2020).

According to scientific studies, young victims want to report but feel ashamed and embarrassed to do so (Bauer et al., 2020). Perceiving that one cannot change the outcome of the online sexual harassment decreases the chance that the victim reports to the service provider (Van Royen et al., 2016). When the platform approves an incident report as online sexual harassment, it makes the victim feel validated and supported by the platform (Blackwell et al., 2017). Lack of knowledge about what online sexual harassment content or

behavior should be reported and low awareness about the severity of those harassing behaviors decrease the chance that the victim reports to the platform (Blackwell et al., 2017).

To wrap up, the reasons why online sexual harassment victims do not report include:

1. Platform-related reasons: victims think the platforms do not help or do not do anything after reporting, the reporting procedure for victims takes too much effort, victims think the platforms do not provide clear guidelines on how to report, replies from social media are non-existent or unhelpful and too late, there is a lack of human interaction or response, the platforms do not consider victims' experiences to be online sexual harassment;
2. Personal reasons: victims lack knowledge about online sexual harassment reporting (victims do not know online sexual harassment behaviors are reportable, do not know what online sexual harassment content or behaviors should be reported), victims have doubts about the severity of those harassing behaviors (victims just want to move on, feel the problem is too trivial), victims feel embarrassed or ashamed, victims have doubts about the the outcomes of reporting (they think their complaints will not lead to anything).

What victims want is that the harassment would be stopped, the harassers would be prevented from continuing, and the harasser would be removed from social media (Victims' Commissioner, 2022).

5.8 Legal framework - Responsibilities of online platforms to protect and support victims of online sexual harassment

Overall, the international and regional instruments addressing online or technology-facilitated sexual harassment include: the CEDAM Committee General Recommendation No. 33; the Council of Europe Recommendation on Preventing and Combating Sexism; the Council of Europe Gender Equality Strategy; the European Union (EU) Gender Equality Strategy; the EU Strategy on Victims' Rights; Council of Europe Convention 108+ and the General Data Protection Directive; the EU Digital Services Act (DSA); the Proposal for e-Evidence; and, the European Code of Conduct on Countering Illegal Hate Speech Online.

With regard to the responsibilities of online platforms to protect and support victims of online sexual harassment, this report analyzes five legal and policy-setting instruments: two legally binding treaties of international human rights law i.e. the Istanbul Convention and the Budapest Convention (section 5.8.1); one legally binding regional Directive, i.e. the DSA (5.8.2); one non-binding international policy instrument i.e. the United Nations Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights (UNGPs) (section 5.8.3); and one co-regulatory non-binding regional instrument, i.e. the EU Conduct on Countering Illegal Hate Speech Online (section 5.8.3).

5.8.1 Istanbul and Budapest Conventions

The Budapest Convention was the first international legally binding treaty addressing Internet and computer crime (cybercrime) by harmonizing national laws, improving investigative techniques, and increasing cooperation among nations. It entered into force on 1 July 2004 and, to date it was ratified by 67 States. The Istanbul Convention and the Budapest Convention are complementary on preventing and combating sexual harassment in digital spaces. Analyzing both the ***Istanbul and Budapest Conventions*** (Van der Wilk, 2021), social media platforms should meet the following requirements:

- **Assistance in individual/collective complaints (Art. 21 of the Istanbul Convention)** Victims of online and technology-facilitated violence should be informed and guided in their willingness to access individual or collective regional or international complaints mechanisms if national judicial instances have been exhausted.
- **Telephone helplines (Art. 24 of the Istanbul Convention)** Regarding online and technology-facilitated violence, it is of utmost importance for victims to be able to access helplines either by phone, by chat or instant messaging, 24/7, from their own country and from abroad, so as to receive counselling regarding the abuse they suffered as well as information on the immediate first steps to take (such as keeping evidence via screenshots or recordings) and the path to follow to find remedies.
- **Reporting (Art. 27 and 28 of the Istanbul Convention)** With regard to online forms of harassment, users of internet platforms should be able to access immediate reporting mechanisms both through the service providers' platforms and through

law-enforcement investigation processes. Professionals who come across cases of online and technology-facilitated violence via publicly available sources should be able to report it on a law-enforcement platform and/or directly to law enforcement bodies (for example, at a police station).

5.8.2 Digital Service Act

The Digital Service Act (DSA), adopted in November 2022, contains due-diligence obligations that apply to digital services that connect users to content and new procedures for faster removal of illegal content and for improved protection of the users' human rights (European Commission, 2020). More specifically, the DSA establishes new safeguards for users and transparency requirements for platforms such as:

- **Articles 13 and 23 Transparency reporting obligations for providers of intermediary services** Providers of intermediary services will further have to publish reports at least once a year on any content moderation they engaged in. This includes information about orders received from national authorities; content moderation engaged at their own initiative; the number of complaints received through the internal complaint-handling systems; any use made of automated means for the purpose of content moderation; the number of notices received under the notice-and-action procedure (only for hosting providers); information about disputes filed with the out-of-court dispute settlement bodies; and suspension measures taken in

response to the posting of manifestly illegal content, manifestly unfounded notices and the submission of manifestly unfounded complaints.

- **Article 17 Internal complaint-handling system** Online platforms shall ensure that their internal complaint-handling systems are easy to access, user-friendly and enable and facilitate the submission of sufficiently precise and adequately substantiated complaints. Online platforms should handle complaints submitted through their internal complaint-handling system in a timely, diligent and objective manner. Online platforms shall inform complainants without undue delay of the decision they have taken. Online platforms shall ensure that the decisions are not solely taken based on automated means.

5.8.3 The United Nations Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights

The United Nations Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights articulate a set of guidelines for States and companies to prevent and address human rights abuses committed in business settings. More specifically, these UN Guiding Principles outline the due diligence process through which companies can identify their negative human rights impacts and demonstrate that their policies and procedures are adequate to address them. Furthermore, businesses have the responsibility to respect human rights by having in place remedial processes to compensate for adverse impacts on human rights.

5.8.4 Code of conduct on countering illegal hate speech online

In May 2016, the European Commission agreed with Facebook, Microsoft, Twitter and YouTube on a Code of conduct on countering illegal hate speech online (European Commission, 2016). In the course of 2018, Instagram, Snapchat and Dailymotion joined the Code of Conduct, Jeuxvideo.com in January 2019, TikTok in 2020 and LinkedIn in 2021. In May and June 2022, respectively, Rakuten Viber and Twitch announced their participation to the Code of Conduct. The purpose of this Code is to establish standardized procedures to ensure that illegal online hate speech is expeditiously acted upon by online intermediaries upon receipt of a valid notification. According to the code of conduct monitoring results in 2021, sexual orientation was the most commonly reported ground of hate speech (18.2%) compared with percentages from other forms of hate speech. Still, despite the fact that this Code covers some types of online sexual harassment such as gender and sexual orientation based online hate speech, it should be noted that it does not cover other types of online sexual harassment such as unwanted sexual attention or sexual coercion.

More specifically, the Code of conduct on countering illegal hate speech online (European Commission, 2016) requests social media platforms to:

- have rules and community standards that prohibit hate speech and put in place systems and teams to review content that is reported to violate these standards;
- review the majority of the content of valid notifications within 24 hours and remove or disable access to hate speech content, if necessary;
- engage in partnerships and training activities with civil society in order to enlarge their network of trusted reporters;

- designate national contact points for receiving notices, in particular by national authorities;
- promote transparency towards users as well as to the general public.

6. REPORTING ONLINE SEXUAL HARASSMENT TO SOCIAL MEDIA PLATFORMS

The legal framework mentioned in Section 5.8 above lays the foundation for the standards that platforms should follow to aid victims of online sexual harassment, such as establishing an efficient reporting system. This section presents a set of evaluation criteria specifically designed to assess reporting systems aimed at combating online sexual harassment. These criteria are based on the legal framework established at the European Council and European Union levels, as well as the usability standards outlined in the ISO framework. We provide an in-depth examination of the current user self-reporting processes on Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter, accompanied by a critical evaluation of their system designs. Additionally, we analyze the Transparency Centers of these platforms and offer recommendations to enhance their transparency reports.

6.1 User self-reporting system evaluation items

In our endeavor to pinpoint shortcomings in the reporting system, we employ the well-established concept of usability, as originally articulated by Nielsen (Nielsen, 1994). The International Organization for Standardization (ISO) further refines this concept in ISO 9241-11 (part 11), defining usability as the product's capacity to effectively, efficiently, and

satisfactorily assist users in attaining specified objectives within a defined context of application. To tailor the usability framework and align it with the legal framework established by the European Council and European Union in the context of addressing online sexual harassment, we propose the following evaluation criteria:

Users can report an online sexual harassment case to social media platforms effectively, efficiently, and with satisfaction. Specifically, users should be:

- a) Satisfied with the ease of using the system for reporting.
- b) Satisfied with the transparency of the reporting system.
- c) Able to learn how to report easily, with clear information provided by the reporting system, including help, on-screen messages, and other documentation.
- d) Able to find the information they need without difficulty.
- e) Assisted effectively in resolving the issue of sexual harassment.
- f) Overall satisfied with the reporting system.

We employ a user flow diagram (Munro, 2020) to visually represent the user self-reporting process. Given variations in the reporting process across different platforms, we have chosen to test Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter. These platforms are among the most widely used social media platforms globally and are frequent settings for online sexual harassment, as discussed in Section 5.5. It's important to note that all tests were conducted by the first author of this report in July/August 2022, using iOS 15.5 on an iPhone 13. All reports were submitted through the in-app user self-reporting system, using the author's own social media account to report online sexual harassment content or accounts

to the platform. The testing aimed to simulate the interaction process of the reporting system, with reporting results not included in this evaluation.

6.2 Reporting online sexual harassment to Facebook Messenger

When a user reports a sexual harassment message sent via a private chat in Facebook Messenger, the user flow is as shown in Figure 7 (Test on July.12th 2022). The process begins with a problem selection page. Here, the on-screen messages reassure the user that their report will be anonymous, and they are advised to contact local emergency services if there is an immediate threat. Additionally, a clickable "Learn More" link is provided above the "Submit Report" button. Clicking "Learn More" allows the user to access detailed explanations of the Community Standards in Messenger Help Center (Messenger Help Center, n.d.), which outlines behaviors that violate Messenger Community Standards. Upon clicking "Submit Report," a thank you page is displayed. On this page, Facebook Messenger acknowledges the user's report with the on-screen message. Below this message, Facebook Messenger offers further actions for the user to consider: 1) Mute chat (Turn off call and message notifications for this chat), 2) Block (Block the people on Facebook Messenger), 3) View Community Standards (Learn more about Facebook's Community Standards).

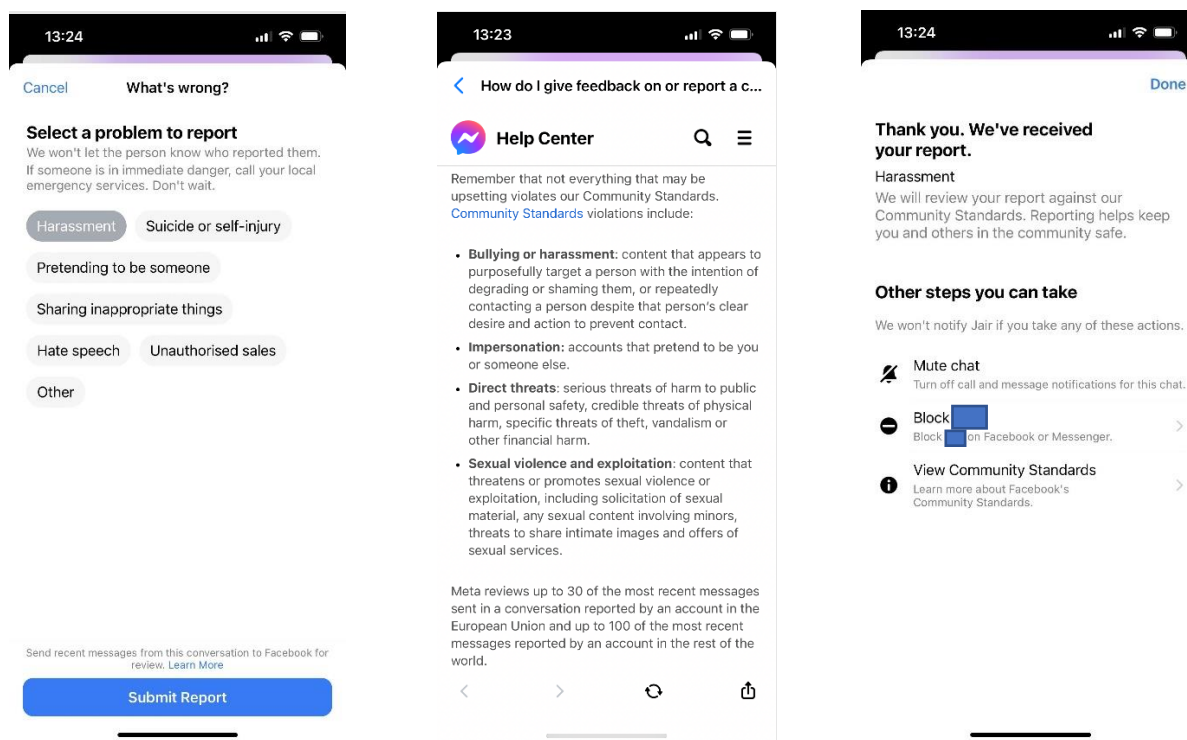


Figure 7. Report sexual harassment to Facebook Messenger. Left – Select a problem page. Middle – Learn more page. Right – Thank you page.

6.2.1 Pitfalls of Facebook Messenger reporting system

During the 'Select a problem page', distinguishing between Harassment, Sharing inappropriate content, and Hate speech is challenging, and there is a lack of guidance on where to find the definitions for these options. On the 'Thank you page', users are not informed about the timing or process of report resolution or where to check the report's outcome. Throughout the reporting process, Messenger does not offer recommendations or access to helplines, law enforcement channels, or regional/international complaint services.

6.3 Reporting online sexual harassment to Facebook

When a user reports an online sexual harassment comment or post to Facebook, the user journey is depicted in Figure 8 (Test conducted on July 12, 2022). Similar to the Messenger process, the initial step involves selecting the type of problem. However, in Facebook's 'Select a problem page,' there are additional options available to the user, including 'I'm not sure' and 'Something else.' Upon choosing the type of problem, a 'Community Standards page' is automatically presented. On this page, users can explicitly familiarize themselves with the definition of harassment.

Once the user has reviewed the rules and confirmed the report, they are directed to the 'Thank you page,' where Facebook explicitly conveys three key pieces of information: Report received ('Your report helps us to improve our processes and keeps Facebook safe for everyone'). Awaiting review ('We use technology and review teams to remove anything that does not follow our standards as quickly as possible'). Decision made ('We'll send you a notification to review the outcome in your Support Inbox as soon as possible'). Following the 'Thank you page,' a 'More options page' becomes available. On this page, the user can opt to block the individual, hide all posts from them, or undo the report. Facebook also assures the user that these actions will not be disclosed to the reported person.

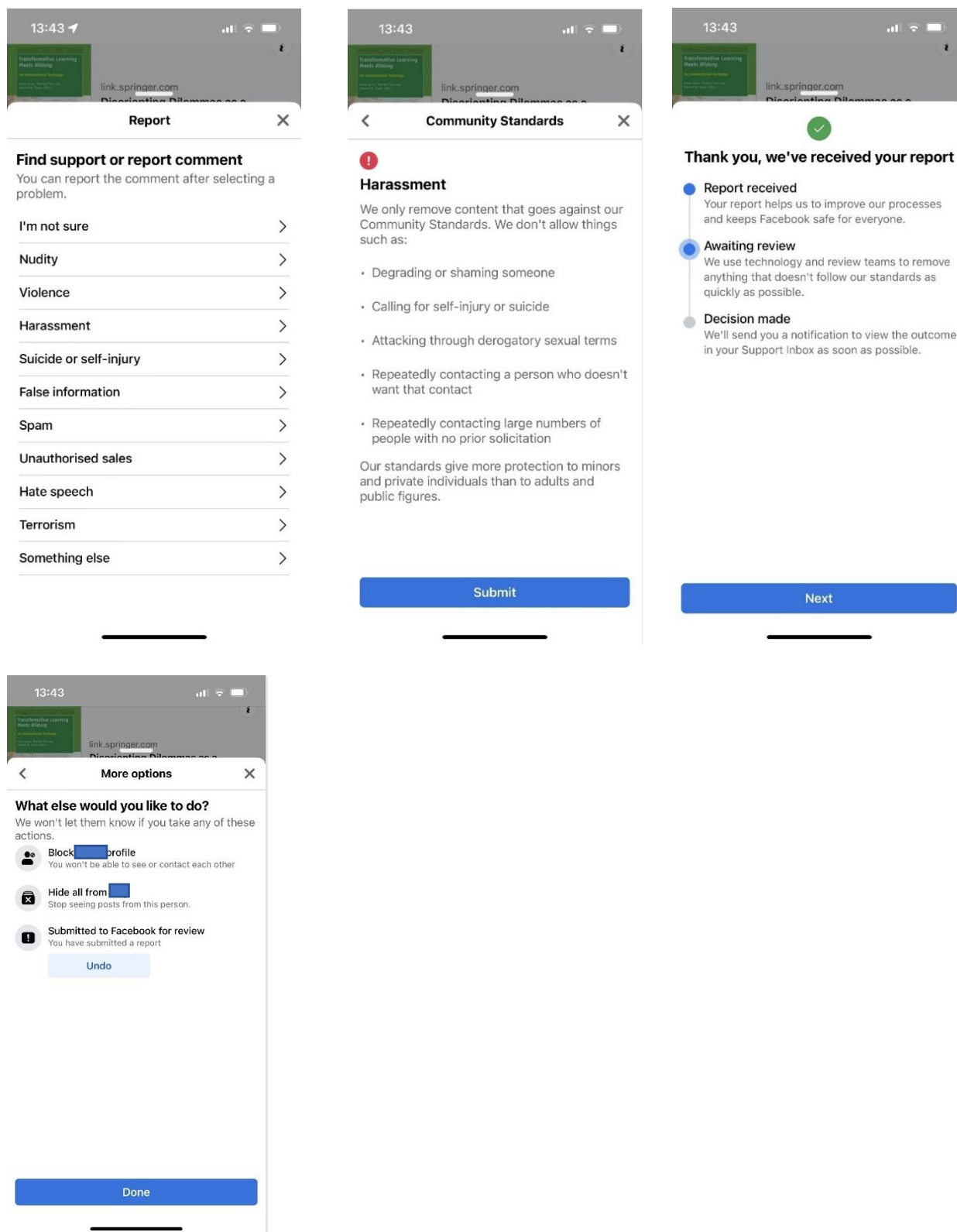


Figure 8. Report a sexual harassment comment or post to Facebook. First screenshot – Select a problem page. Second screenshot – Community Standards page. Third screenshot – Thank you page. Forth screenshot – More options page.

When a user wishes to review the actions and decisions taken, the user journey is depicted in Figure 9. The user should navigate to the Menu page, locate the Support Inbox under the Help & Support drop-down menu, and click on it. Subsequently, the user will have access to the records of all taken actions and decisions on their reports.

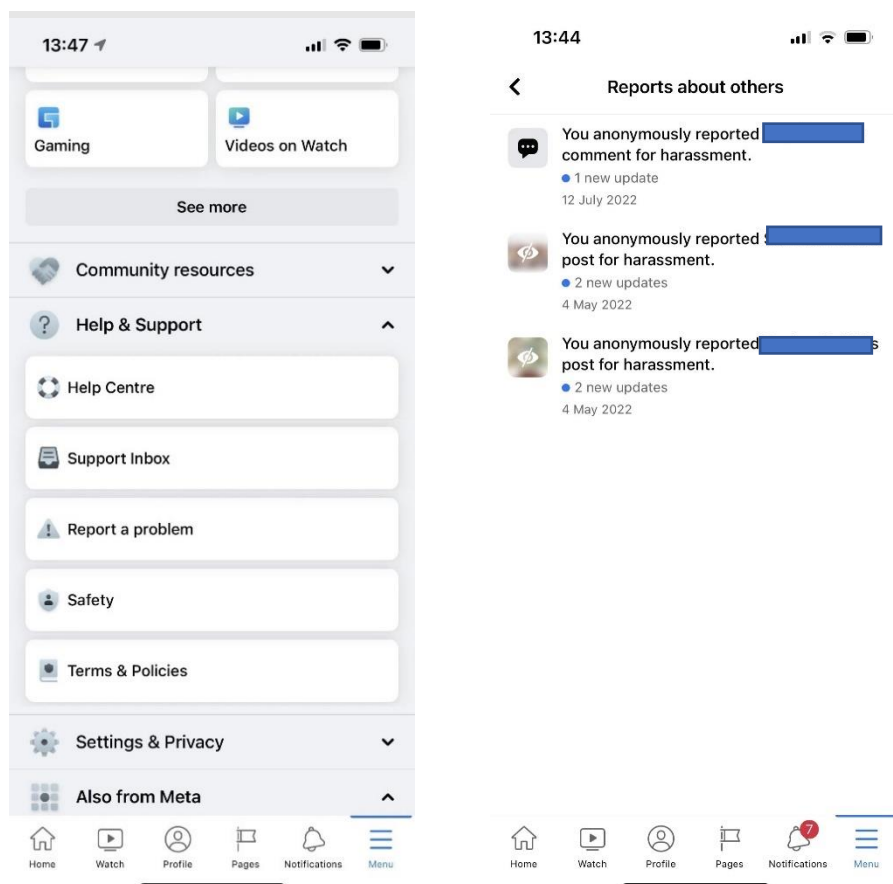


Figure 9. Check decision-making result in Facebook

6.3.1 Pitfalls of Facebook reporting system

On the 'Select a problem' page, users may encounter challenges in selecting between 'I'm not sure,' 'Harassment,' and 'Something else.' It's worth noting that throughout the reporting process, Messenger does not offer recommendations or provide access to helplines, law enforcement channels, or regional/international complaint services.

6.4 Reporting online sexual harassment to Instagram Messenger

When a user reports an online sexual harassment message within a private chat on Instagram, the user's path is outlined in Figure 10 (Test conducted on July 13, 2022). The process initiates with the 'Select a problem' page, where on-screen messages assure the user that the platform will not notify the reported account. Additionally, a 'Learn more about reporting' option is available, allowing users to access community standards. Upon selecting the problem 'Bullying or harassment,' a 'Guideline page' is displayed, explaining what constitutes bullying or harassment. On this page, an on-screen message suggests calling emergency services in immediate danger situations. Furthermore, the page clarifies bullying or harassment with the message: 'We take action if we find: messages that target private individuals to degrade or shame them, messages that contain personal information shared to harass or blackmail people.'. Upon clicking 'Submit report' on the 'Guideline Page,' the 'Thank you page' appears. On this page, users encounter a thank you message. Instagram also suggests options like blocking, restricting, or unfollowing the reported person. By clicking 'Learn more,' users can access the community guidelines (Instagram Help Center, 2019).

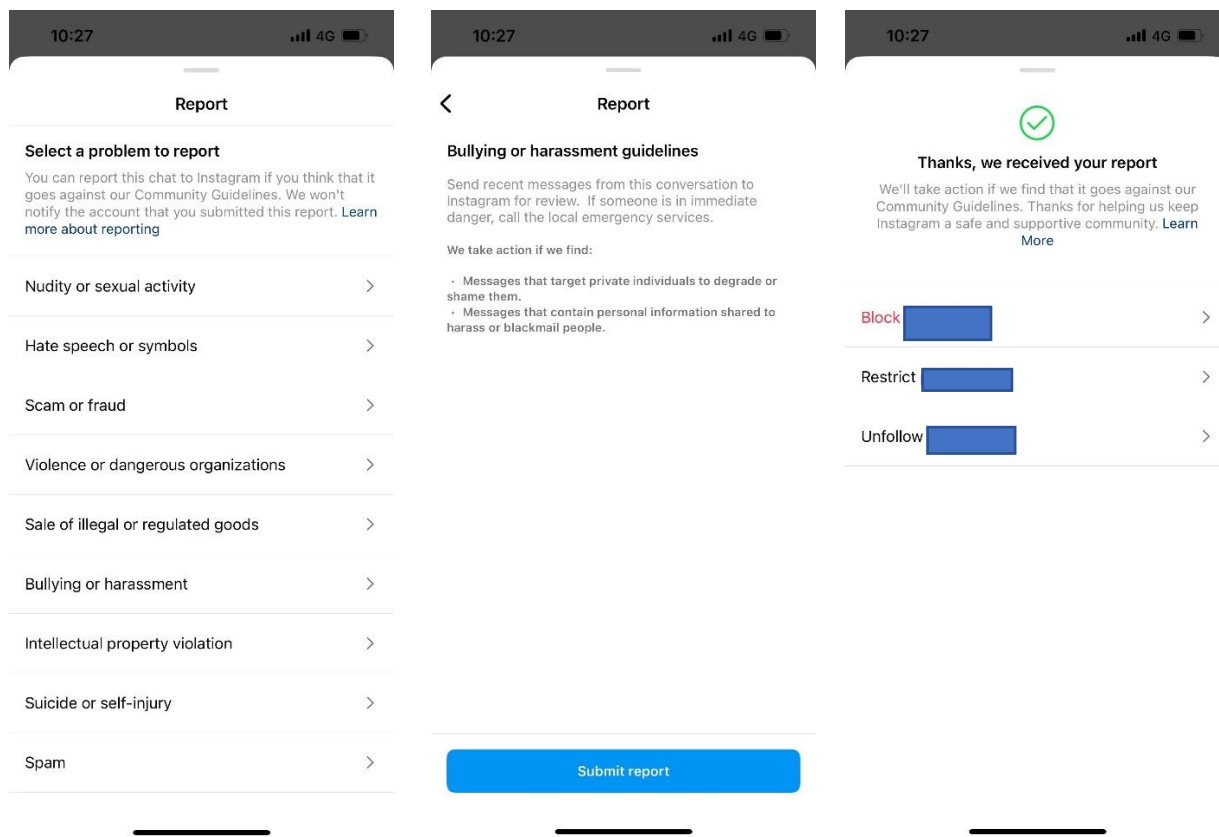


Figure 10. Report harassment message to Instagram Direct Messenger. Left – Select a problem page. Middle – Guideline page. Right – Thank you page.

Within the community guidelines, users can gain insights into behaviors that are discouraged or prohibited, along with Instagram's approach to addressing them. Furthermore, the community guidelines emphasize that even individuals without an Instagram account have the option to submit a report through a web link.

6.4.1 Pitfalls of the Instagram Messenger reporting system

During the 'Guideline page' stage, Instagram does not specify that they will take action in response to a user receiving unwanted sexual messages, images, videos, or sexual threats. Moreover, on the 'Thank you page,' there is a lack of information regarding the timeline for Instagram's response to the report, how the user can check or receive notifications about

the reporting outcome. Throughout the reporting process, Instagram does not offer recommendations or provide access to helplines, law enforcement channels, or regional/international complaint services.

6.5 Reporting online sexual harassment to Instagram

When a user reports a sexual harassment comment under an Instagram post, the user journey is illustrated in Figure 11 (Test conducted on July 13, 2022). Similar to reporting a private message in Instagram Messenger, the initial step involves the user selecting a problem. However, distinctions emerge with the 'Guidelines page' and 'Thank you page.' On the 'Guidelines page,' Instagram provides a message clarifying what content they will remove and how the user should proceed ('We remove: Comments that target private individuals to degrade or shame them. Comments that contain personal information shared to harass or blackmail people. Threats to post intimate images of others. We only review reported comments. If you find other harassing comments, please report them separately.'). On the 'Thank you page,' users can find details regarding Instagram's handling of the reported comment and where to check the report's outcome ('Report received: Your report helps us improve our processes and keeps Instagram safe for everyone. Awaiting review: We either use technology or a review team to remove anything that does not adhere to our standards as quickly as possible. Decision made: We'll send you a notification to review the outcome in your support requests as soon as possible').

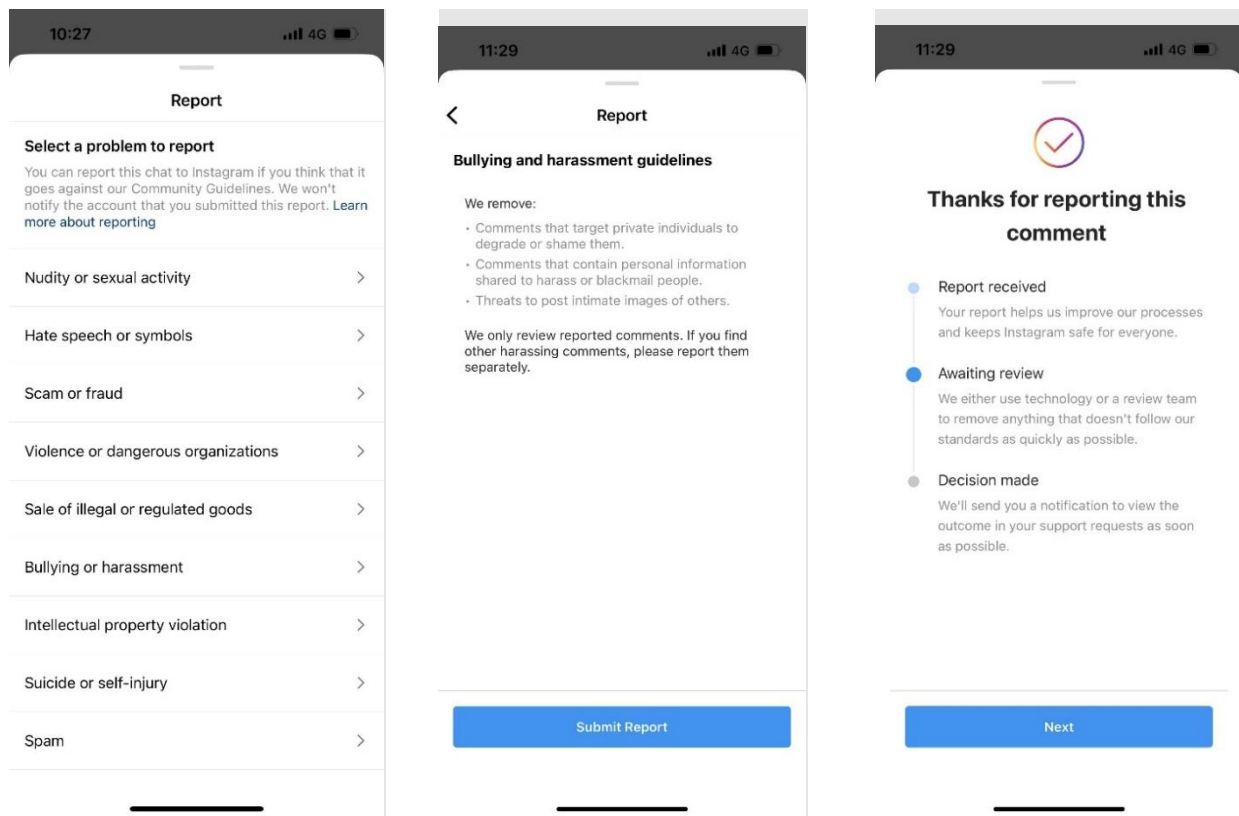


Figure 11. Report harassment post or comment to Instagram. Left – Select a problem page. Middle – Guidelines page. Right – Thank you page.

Following the submission of a report, users can review the report's outcome through the help feature. The steps are outlined in Figure 12: Initially, the user must access their personal settings, and within the Help feature, they can locate the 'Support Request' option. By clicking on it, users can access a comprehensive overview of the progress, actions taken, and decisions made regarding their reports.

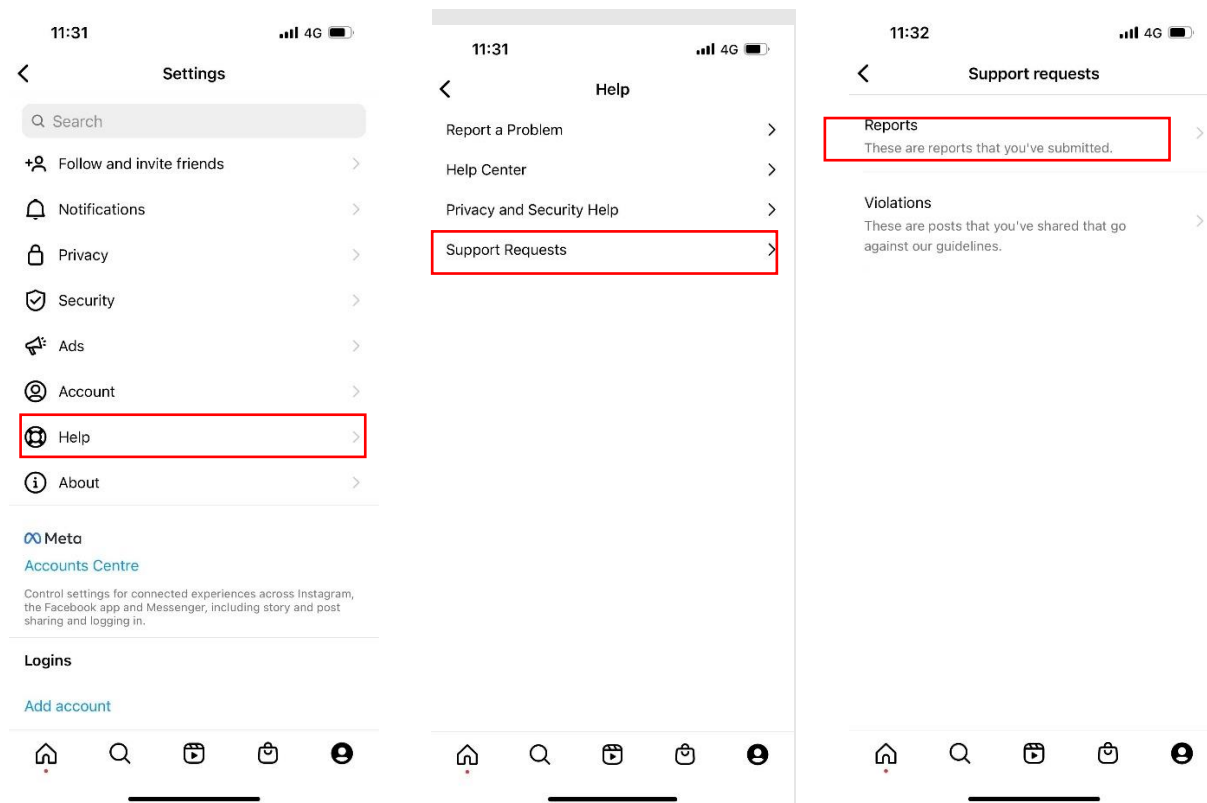


Figure 12. Check decision-making result in Instagram Messenger

6.5.1 Pitfalls of the Instagram reporting system

While on the 'Guideline page,' Instagram does not specify their action regarding unwanted sexual intimate messages or sexual threats within comments. On the 'Thank you page,' users may encounter difficulty in locating information about where to check the report's outcome. Importantly, throughout the reporting process, Instagram does not offer guidance or access to helplines, law enforcement channels, or regional/international complaint services.

6.6 Facebook/Instagram Transparency Center

Facebook and Instagram regularly release the Community Standards Enforcement Report on a quarterly basis. The most recent reports concerning 'Bullying and Harassment' are accessible in the transparency center (Meta, 2022). In their report, we cannot find any data

or information about the total number of reports from users received through the reporting system, also we cannot find the number of declined user reports. In their report, we can see the prevalence of bullying and harassment, the total number of content that Facebook/Instagram took action on for bullying and harassment (including both user reports and content that they found proactively), the proactive rate (content that they found proactively divided by the total number of content they took action on), the number of appealed content (the content actioned for which people requested another review during the reporting period), and the number of restored content (content that is appealed or when they discover issues themselves). We manually calculated the number of user reports they have taken action upon and created Figure 13 for Facebook and Figure 14 for Instagram. In Figure 13, we see a decreasing trend of user reports taken action upon by Facebook after Jan-Mar 2021. A growing percentage of content has been proactively taken action upon by Facebook before user reports (Meta, 2022).

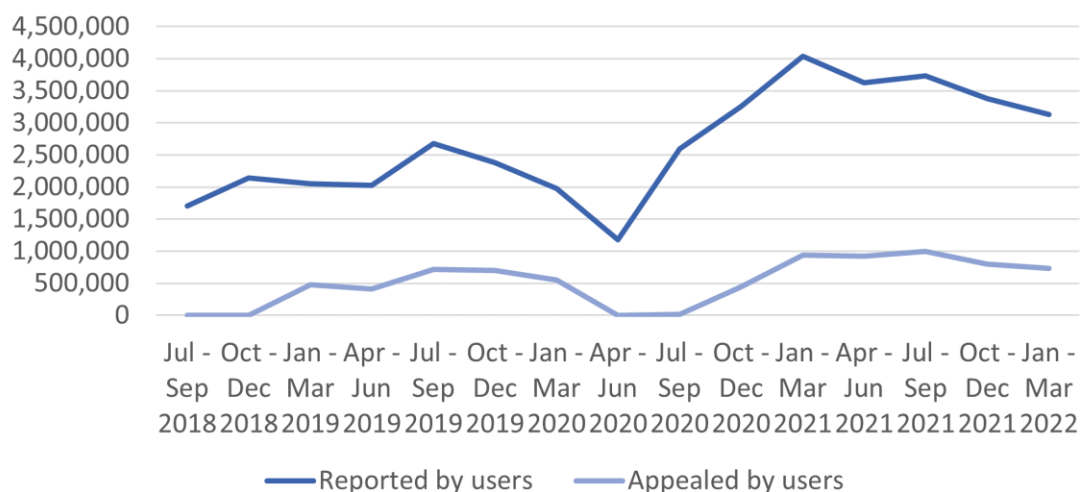
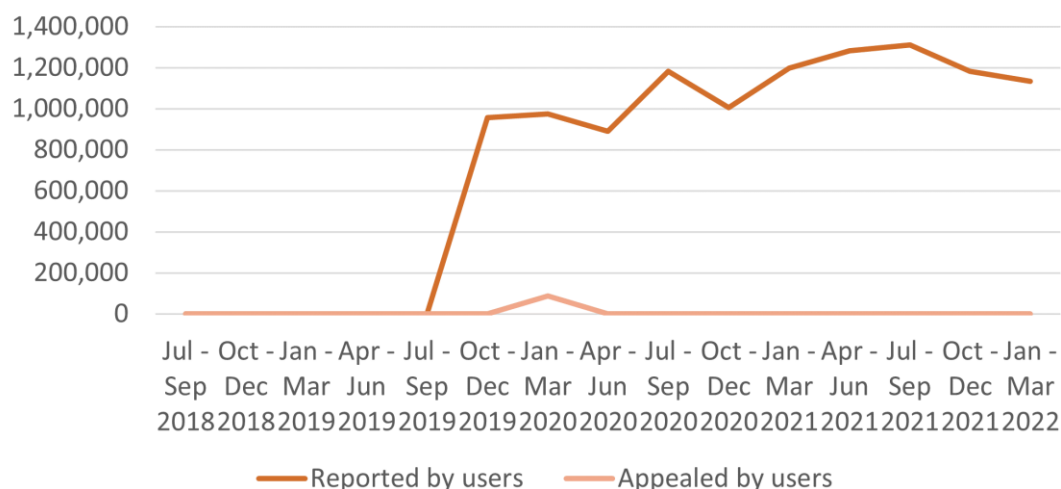


Figure 13. Number of user report (about bullying and harassment) taken action upon by Facebook.

In Figure 14, we see a stable number of user reports (taken action upon by Instagram) since Jan – Mar 2021. A growing percentage of content has been proactively taken action upon by Instagram before user reports (Meta, 2022).



To wrap up:

In an effort to enhance transparency, we advise Facebook/Instagram to include the following key information in their quarterly report:

1. The total number of user-generated reports received through the reporting system.
2. The quantity of user reports declined due to non-violation of community standards.
3. Detailed explanations for the rejection of these user reports.
4. The average response time for Facebook/Instagram to address a user's report.

6.7 Reporting online sexual harassment to TikTok

When a user reports a sexually harassing comment on TikTok, the user's journey is illustrated in Figure 15 (Test on July 13th, 2022). The process begins with the appearance of the 'Select problem page.' Upon selecting 'Bullying and harassment,' the 'Explain page' is displayed, featuring an on-screen message that delineates the prohibited behaviors related to bullying and harassment on TikTok. These behaviors encompass content degrading somebody or wishing them harm, content that encourages coordinated harassment, content showcasing physical bullying intended to humiliate someone, content involving sexual harassment, and content making threats to disclose personal information. Upon confirming the report submission, a 'Thank you page' appears, featuring an on-screen thank you message. It is worth noting that, unlike Facebook and Instagram, TikTok's thank you page includes a button with a direct link to the reporting result. However, apart from the thank you page following the report, we did not identify another access point for checking the results of the report. In contrast, Facebook and Instagram allow users to access report results through the help/support feature in the settings. Reporting a video on TikTok follows a similar procedure as reporting a comment.

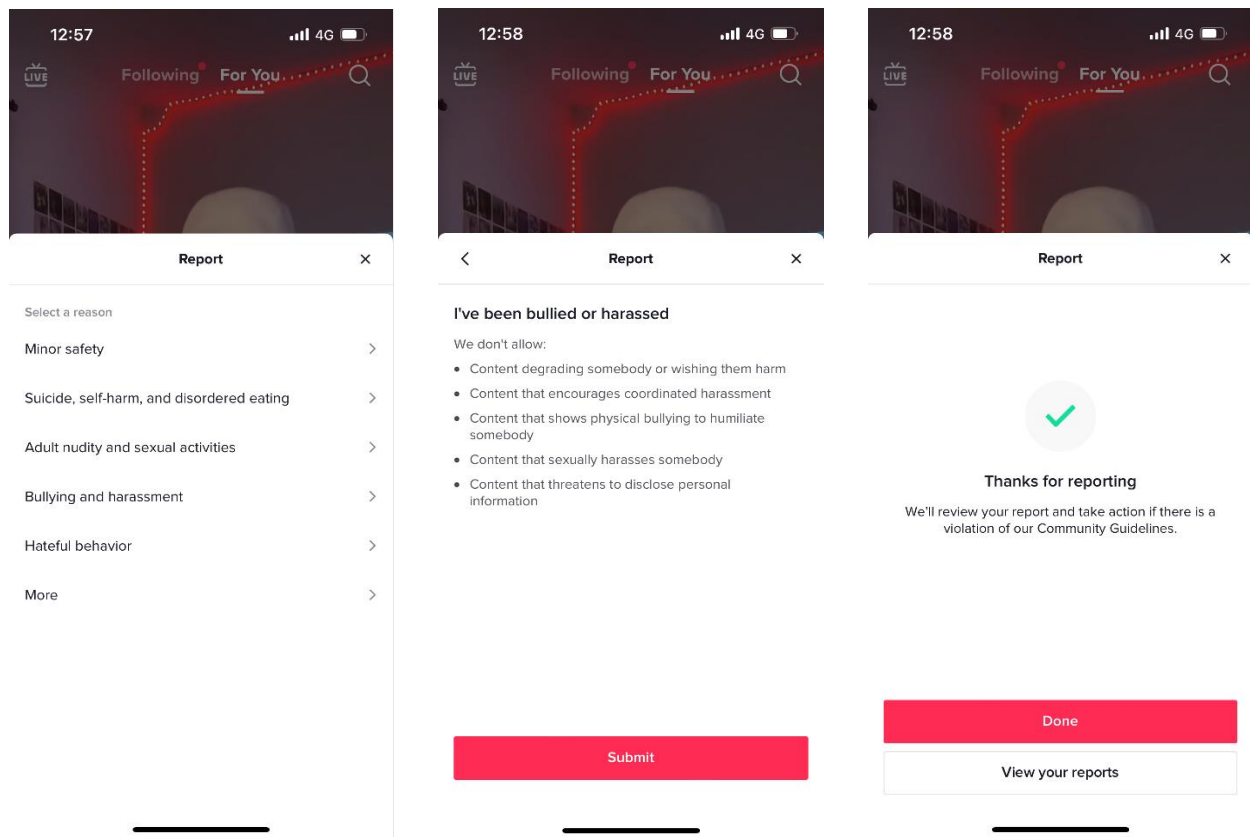


Figure 15. Report sexual harassment content to TikTok. Left – Select problem page. Middle – Explain page. Right – Thank you page.

6.7.1 Pitfalls of the TikTok reporting system

Despite the presence of a direct access point to view reports on the 'Thank you page' at the conclusion of the reporting process, TikTok leaves the user with unclear information regarding the timing of report handling, the manner in which the report will be addressed, notification of the reporting result, and the location for checking the report's outcome. In contrast, Facebook and Instagram offer accessible report results through the help/support feature in the settings. Throughout the reporting procedure, TikTok does not offer guidance or access to helplines, law-enforcement platforms, or regional and international complaints services.

6.8 TikTok Transparency Center

TikTok released its quarterly reporting results from 2019 until now (TikTok Transparency Center, 2019). In their report, we cannot find any data or information about the total number of reports from users received through the reporting system, the number of declined user reports, the number of removed comments. In their report, we can see the total number of videos removed/restored, total number of videos removed by each sub-policy (in our report we focus on 'harassment and bullying' category) and the corresponding proactive removal rate, removal rate before any views, removal rate within 24 hours, removal volume and rates by country. Based on the removal of 'Harassment and bullying' sub-policy data in their report, we created Figure 16. We see a peak of removal within 24 hours in Jan – Mar 2021 (93.8%), afterwards, the rate of removal within 24 hours decreases and keeps stable around 84%. We also see a growing trend of proactive removal rate, and removal before any views. We see this growing trend of proactive removal also in the Facebook/Instagram transparency center. This is in line with what they have promised – to take proactive action to remove the harmful content.

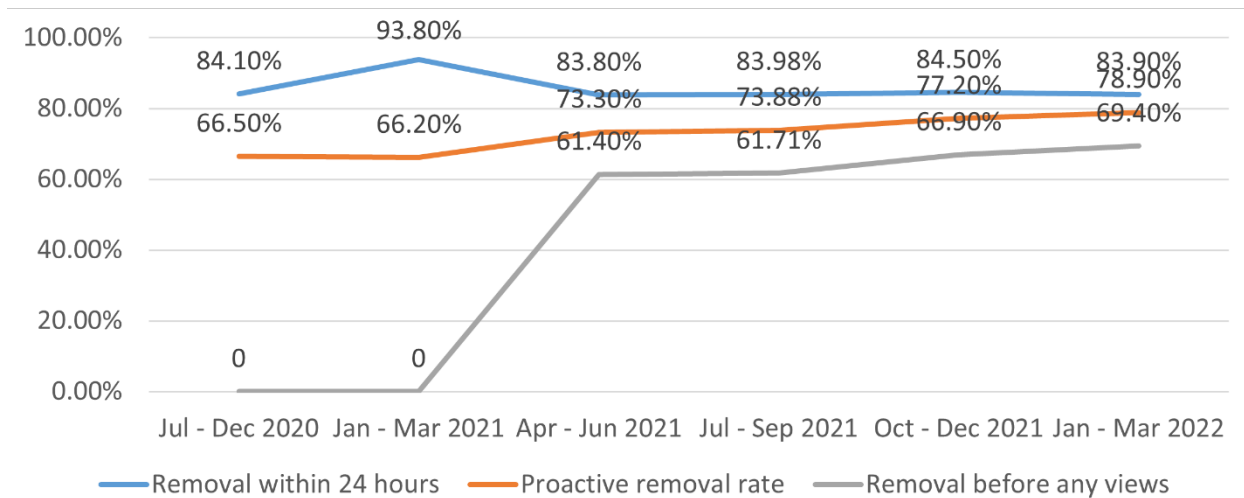


Figure 16. Video removal rate on TikTok. Proactive removal means identifying and removing a video before it is reported. Removal within 24 hours means removing the video within 24 hours of it being posted on the platform.

Hence, it is imperative to ensure the provision of comprehensive information regarding the number of declined user reports, the rationale behind declining such reports, and the response time taken by TikTok for user reports.

To wrap up:

To enhance transparency, we recommend that TikTok, in their quarterly reports, furnishes clear and adequate information on the following aspects:

1. The total count of user reports received through the reporting system.
2. The quantity of user reports that have been declined due to non-breaches of community standards.
3. The specific grounds for declining these user reports.
4. The average response time for TikTok to address user reports.

6.9 Reporting online sexual harassment to Twitter Direct Message

When a user reports a sexual harassment message within a Twitter Direct Message, the user's journey is illustrated in Figure 17 (Test on July 13th, 2022). Twitter's reporting process distinguishes itself from that of Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok by seeking more context about the user's harassment situation. The procedure commences with the first two pages designated for users to select the nature of the problem they're encountering. The first page inquires how someone is being abusive or harmful, offering options such as 'Being disrespectful or offensive,' 'Posting my private information,' 'Engaging in targeted harassment,' 'Directing hate against a protected category (e.g., race, caste, religion, gender, orientation, disability),' 'Threatening violence or physical harm,' and 'Encouraging or endorsing suicide or self-harm.' The second page further refines the issue by inquiring whether it pertains to spam or abusive/harassment. The third page enables users to select up to three messages in the conversation to aid Twitter in their investigation. The fourth page provides an opportunity for the user to provide additional details about the incident.

On the concluding 'Thank you page,' Twitter Direct Message assures the user that they will take action should they find the reported person to be in violation of Twitter Rules. Simultaneously, Twitter encourages the user to take actions such as blocking the person or muting them. Links to "Learn more/Twitter rules/Improve your experience" are available on each page for users who wish to access more detailed information.

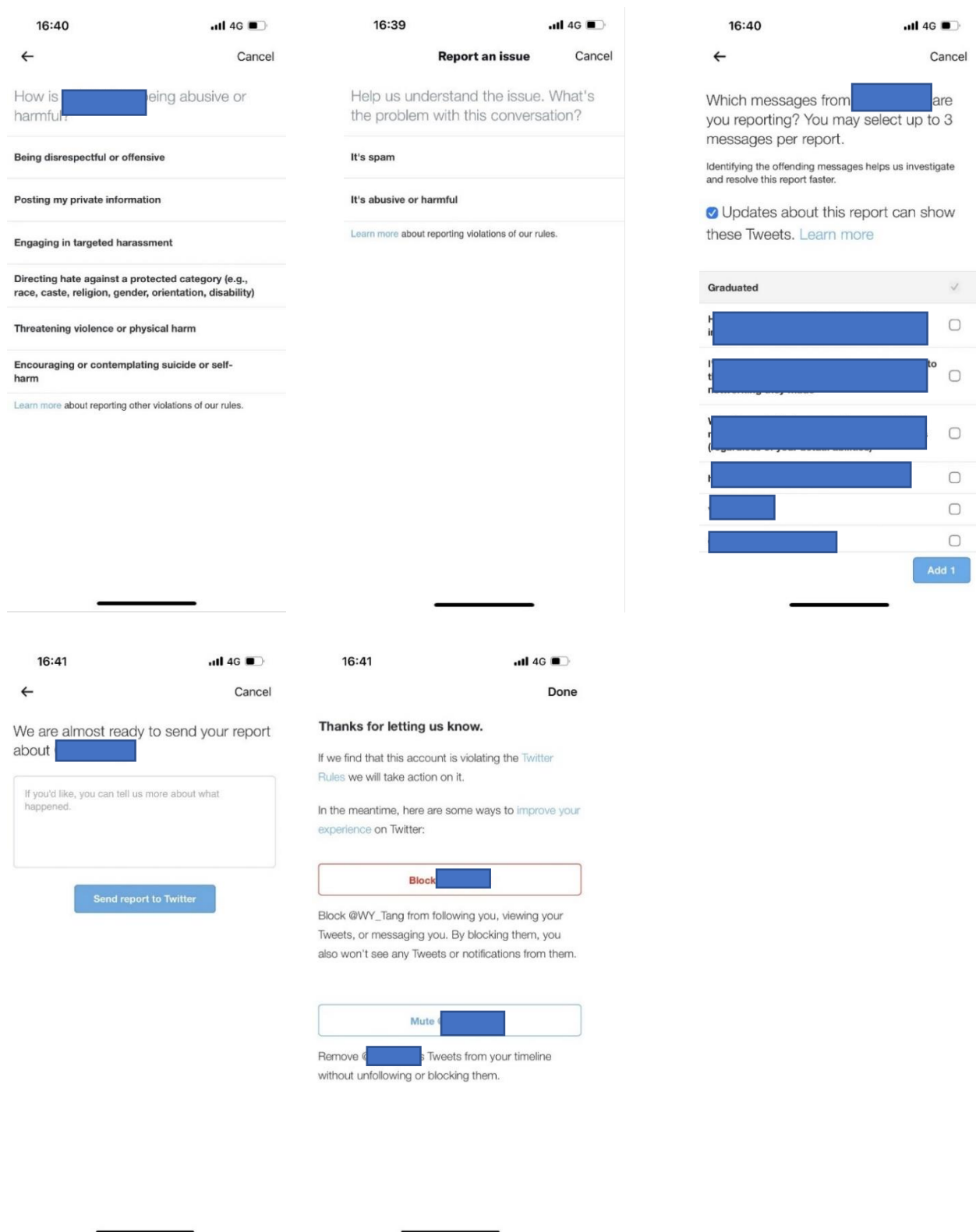


Figure 17. Reporting sexual harassment in Twitter Direct Message. Picture one and two – Select problem page. Picture three and four – Asking user about the harassment context page. Picture five – Thank you page.

6.9.1 Pitfalls of the Twitter Direct Message reporting system

Compared to Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok, Twitter Direct Message offers users the opportunity to provide more detailed context when making a report, which can convey a sense of Twitter's concern for the user's situation. However, certain shortcomings persist. Notably, on the 'Thank you page,' Twitter Direct Message fails to inform the user about the timeline for addressing the report, the methods they will employ for resolution, whether the user will receive notification of the reporting outcome, and where to locate the reporting results. Throughout the reporting process, Twitter Direct Message refrains from suggesting any information or providing access to helplines, law enforcement channels, regional or international complaints services.

6.10 Reporting online sexual harassment to Twitter

When a user reports a sexual harassment comment or post on Twitter, the user flow follows the process depicted in Figure 18 (Test on July 13th, 2022). In comparison to Twitter Direct Message, the reporting procedure on Twitter offers users the opportunity to provide more comprehensive details about their experience. Notably, the explanation page not only defines what constitutes harassment or abusive content but also includes a tweet example to facilitate user understanding of Twitter rules. A significant difference in the process is the inclusion of a 'Welcome page.' As users commence the reporting process, the 'Welcome page' is the initial step. This page emphasizes Twitter's commitment to taking user reports seriously and encourages users to contact local emergency services if they face immediate

danger. Subsequently, the 'Gathering information page' allows users to select a specific problem, each accompanied by a brief explanation. For instance, under the problem titled 'Harassed or intimidated with violence,' small font texts clarify that this category encompasses sexual harassment, group harassment, insults or name-calling, posting private information, threatening to post private information, denial of violent events, violent threats, and celebration of violent acts. Upon problem selection, the 'Gathering information page' presents users with a list of more detailed behaviors related to their chosen problem. Following this, the 'Validate page' outlines specific behaviors associated with the sub-problem the user selected, with an example tweet for users to verify if it aligns with their report. The final step, the 'Review and submit page,' summarizes the user's reporting problem and optionally suggests including another tweet from the person or additional contextual information to aid Twitter's review process. Concluding the process, the 'Thank you page' informs users of the current status of their report, indicating that the report is in the queue, and Twitter will temporarily hide the reported tweet from their timeline. It further explains the anticipated timeframe for review and states that Twitter will notify users of any rule violations found and actions taken as a result. Additionally, Twitter recommends users to mute the reported person, allowing them to remove the person's tweets from their timeline without unfollowing or blocking them.

16:44 4G

Cancel



Hello

We need you to answer a few questions so we can better understand what's going on in this account's profile or Tweets. You'll also have the option to add more info in your own words and add Tweets to this report.

We take reports seriously. If we find a rule violation, we'll either ask them to remove the content or lock or suspend the account.

If there's immediate danger, call your local emergency services in addition to reporting.

Start report

16:44 4G

Cancel

Gathering info

I'm being ...

Why are we asking this?

Attacked because of my identity ☐
Slurs, misgendering, racist or sexist stereotypes, encouraging others to harass, sending hateful imagery

Harassed or intimidated with violence ☐
Sexual harassment, group harassment, insults or name calling, posting private info, threatening to expose private info, violent event denial, violent threats, celebration of violent acts

Spammed ☐
Posting malicious links, misusing hashtags, fake engagement, repetitive replies, Retweets, or Direct Messages.

Shown content related to or encouraged to self-harm ☐

Offered tips or currency — or encouraged to send them — in a way that's deceptive or promotes or causes harm ☐

Next

16:44 4G

Cancel

Gathering info

How is [redacted] doing this?

Why are we asking this?

Sexually harassing me ☐

Sending me unwanted adult content ☐

Posting my private info ☐

Threatening to expose or hack my private info ☐

Sharing my image or likeness without permission ☐

Wishing harm on me ☐

Insulting me or name-calling ☐

Encouraging others to harass me ☐

Denying a violent event, such as Sandy Hook, the Holocaust, and the September 11th attacks ☐

Threatening me with violence ☐

Celebrating or praising violent acts ☐

Next

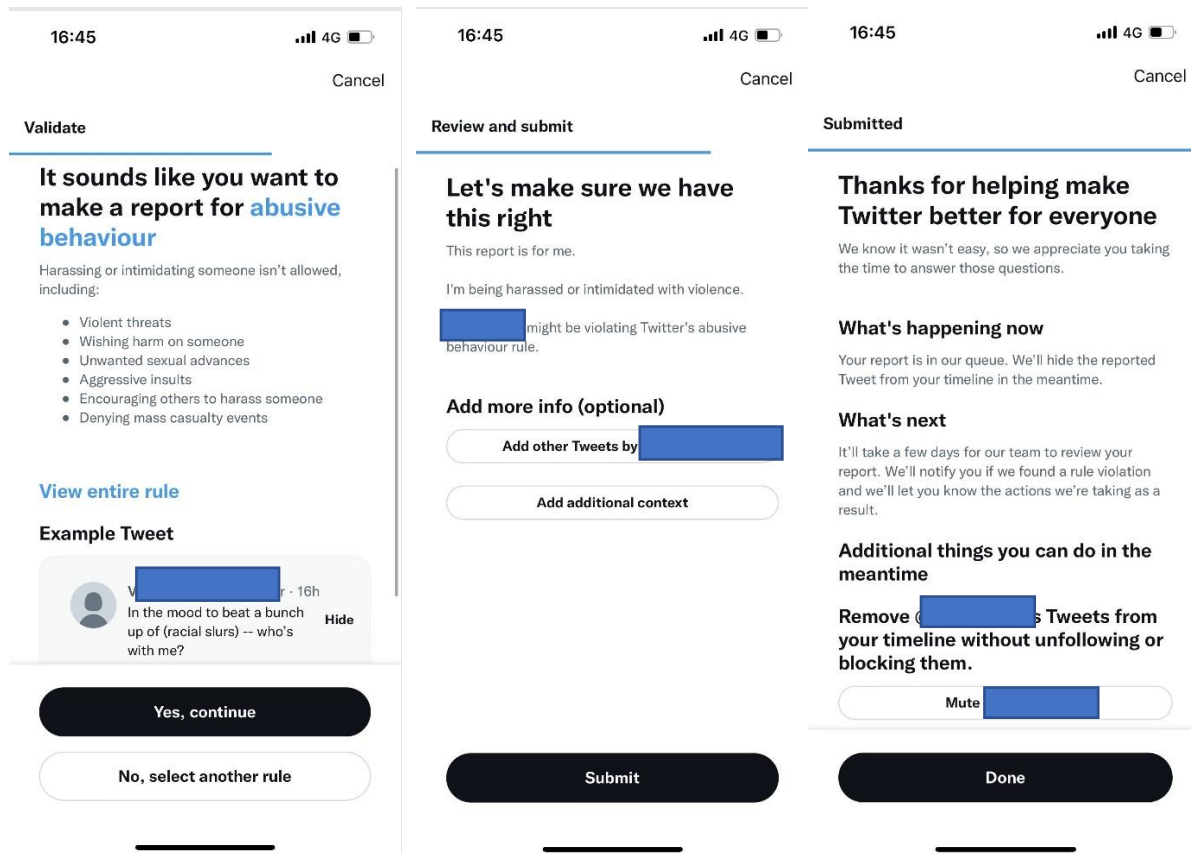


Figure 18. Reporting sexual harassment content to Twitter. Picture one – Welcome page. Picture two and three – Gather information page. Picture four – Validate page. Picture five – Review and submit page. Picture six – Thank you page.

6.10.1 Pitfalls of the Twitter reporting system

In contrast to Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter Direct Message, the Twitter reporting system affords users the opportunity to provide more detailed contextual information when making a report. Notably, the 'Welcome page' underscores Twitter's commitment and serious approach to addressing user reports. Upon reaching the 'Thank you page,' Twitter provides clear communication, informing the user that the reported content has been removed from their timeline. Furthermore, Twitter explicitly outlines its process for handling the user's report, assuring them that the Twitter team will review the report within a few days and that the user will be notified of the outcome. However, it is important to note that,

throughout the reporting procedure, Twitter does not offer recommendations or access to helplines, law-enforcement platforms, or regional and international complaint services, which may be considered a limitation in providing comprehensive support to users.

6.11 Twitter Transparency Center

Twitter releases its transparency report every half year to the public (Twitter Transparency Center, 2022). From their report, we can find data about user reports and actions taken by Twitter in each problem category. We select the data of accounts reported/actioned because of abuse/harassment, accounts reported/suspended because of abuse/harassment, and content reported/removed because of abuse/harassment. Based on those data, we created Figure 19. The overall report action rate is lower than 21% throughout the time, but it keeps growing gradually from Jul – Dec 2020. In Jul – Dec 2018 and Jan – Jun 2020, the report action rate is below 8%, but from the public data given by Twitter we cannot deduce the reasons why the report action rate is low/high in a specific period of time. Comparing Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter, Twitter is the only platform that gives public data about the total number of reports from users received through the reporting system. However, we cannot find what the reasons are to decline those user reports.

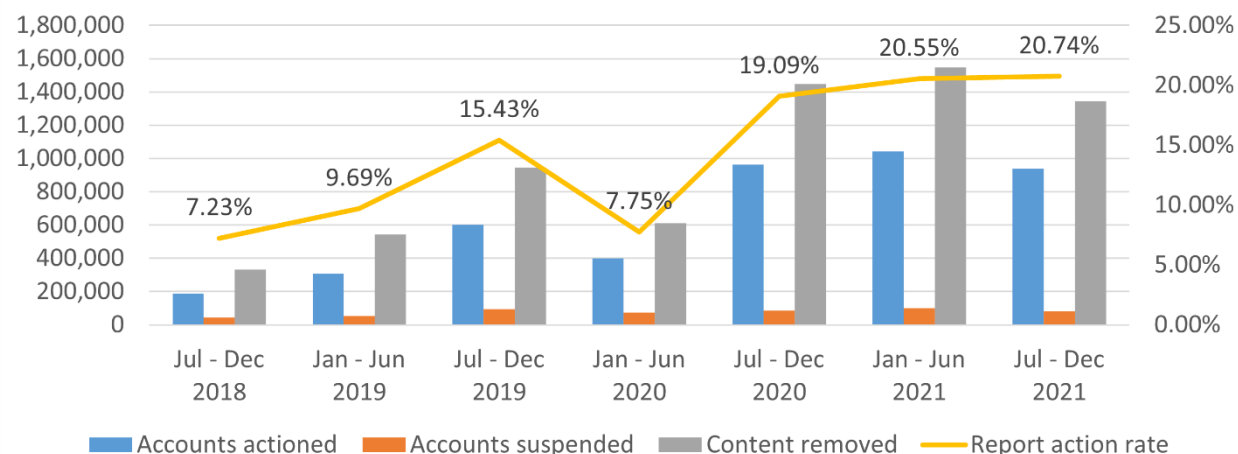


Figure 19. User report and action taken by Twitter. 'Accounts actioned' reflects the number of unique accounts that were suspended or had some content removed for violating the Twitter Rules, including auto-actioned content. 'Accounts suspended' reflects the number of unique accounts that were suspended for violating the Twitter Rules. 'Content removed' reflects the number of unique pieces of content (such as Tweets or an account's profile image, banner, or bio) that Twitter required account owners to remove for violating the Twitter Rules, including auto-actioned content. 'Report action rate' is calculated as accounts reported ("Accounts reported" reflects the total number of unique accounts that users reported for potentially violating the Twitter Rules) divided by accounts actioned.

To wrap up:

To enhance transparency, we propose the following recommendations to Twitter:

1. Clearly outline the reasons for declining user reports.
2. Specify the expected response time for addressing a user's report.

7. PRELIMINARY RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on the analysis presented in Section 6, we put forward the following initial recommendations for platforms. In our ongoing research, we are actively designing and testing new reporting systems, guided by communication theories, and employing both qualitative and quantitative research methods. At this stage, we offer the following preliminary recommendations:

At the beginning of the reporting

1. Clearly convey the platform's commitment to taking user reports seriously. This reassurance is vital, as victims are more likely to report incidents to the service provider when they believe their reports will yield meaningful results (Van Royen et al., 2016).
2. Encourage the user to call local emergency services if there is immediate danger.
3. Emphasize that the fault lies with the perpetrator, not the reporting user. By alleviating feelings of shame and embarrassment, victims will be more willing to report. This is especially important as studies have shown that young victims often want to report but feel ashamed to do so (Bauer et al., 2020). It is essential to help users overcome such feelings and ensure their privacy by ensuring the person reported will not be informed about the reporter's identity.

During the reporting

1. Demonstrate to the user that the platform has acted on previous reports from other users. Such acknowledgment of online sexual harassment incidents validates the

victim's experience and fosters a sense of support from the platform (Blackwell et al., 2017).

2. Allow users to provide a detailed account of their experiences. This aligns with self-disclosure theory (Pearce & Sharp, 1973), which suggests that self-disclosure contributes to personal well-being and satisfaction, effective communication, and competent interaction with others. Offering users the opportunity to self-disclose can enhance their perception that their victimization experience is being understood and increase overall satisfaction.
3. Provide users with the option to submit additional contextual information and evidence.
4. Explain the available options using user-friendly language and concrete examples. The use of simple and clear language and visual aids can significantly improve user understanding. Alternatively, implementing an intelligent system that can automatically categorize the type of reported problem for the user's convenience could be beneficial.

After the reporting

1. Inform the user that immediate action has been taken regarding the harmful content (e.g., content is in a queue for review by the platform, hidden from the public).
2. Clarify what will occur next, including the estimated timeframe for receiving results, how users will be notified about the outcome, and the potential actions the platform may take (e.g., content removal, temporary/permanent account suspension, etc.).

3. Recommend options to enhance the user's experience on the platform, such as blocking, muting, or hiding content.
4. Provide users with information about local helplines, law-enforcement platforms, regional, or international complaint services to further support them.

User report decision making

Transparency reports released by social media platforms indicate that a combination of automated methods and human moderators are employed to determine the outcome of user reports. We recommend the adoption of an AI-driven content moderation system that collaborates with human moderators. This approach can enhance the efficiency of decision-making while reducing the likelihood of errors, as suggested by (Lai et al., 2022). Recognizing that users may not fully trust platforms' automated decision-making processes, involving human moderators in content curation is advisable. Scientific studies have shown that allowing users to provide feedback on algorithmic decisions can bolster their trust in the system, as noted in (Molina et al., 2022).

In the Transparency Center

To foster greater transparency, we advise platforms to furnish comprehensive and easily understandable information regarding the following aspects:

- The total number of reports received from users through the reporting system.
- The number of user reports that have been declined.
- The specific reasons for declining these user reports.
- The expected response time for the platform to address a user's report.

These recommendations are grounded in recent surveys, scientific studies, and our firsthand observations of the social media reporting process. However, we acknowledge the importance of practitioner perspectives. To complement our approach, we also conducted a co-design workshop to solicit input from relevant practitioners on how social media platforms can enhance their interfaces to better support victims of online sexual harassment.

7.1 Feedback from the co-design workshop

In order to collect ideas from relevant stakeholders, we have conducted a co-design workshop during the World Anti-Bullying Forum 2021 (Tan et al., 2021). In this collaborative workshop, participants (n=25, school teachers, practitioners, cyberbullying researchers) assumed the role of product managers responsible for optimizing the user interface of a social media platform to provide enhanced support for victims of online sexual harassment. The workshop's structure involved several key steps: **1) Storytelling for Empathy:** We initiated the workshop by presenting a visual storyboard aimed at fostering empathy and allowing participants to immerse themselves in the experience of an online sexual harassment victim. **2) Group Discussion:** The 25 workshop participants engaged in group discussions to exchange ideas and insights. **3) Solution Generation:** Following the group discussions, each participant was provided with blank sheets to independently record three innovative solutions or ideas. The resulting solutions and ideas gathered during this workshop are summarized in Table 1 for reference and further consideration.

Table 1. Feedbacks from participants in Co-design workshop

Check users' emotional state
"If one person reports, ask how she/he feels – add an emotional rating icon"
Give more support
"Give users the chance to help each other online (bystander)." "When the victim reports her/his case, the platform can issue a message 'It's not your fault.'" "Tell the user he/she matters, to hug herself/himself, self-love" "(In case of young victims) Invite adult people to the reporting process."
Educate users on coping strategies
"Tell the kids about how they can answer to those shaming comments under their selfie, give them the power to say no." "Find ways to encourage rational thinking, not emotional driven communication" "Platforms should use their algorithms to show more content that is anti-bullying." "Social media need to push positive content via their algorithm."
Avoid victim-blaming
"Take away shame, blame, and guilt on the girls. Put the responsibility where it belongs."
Give the user the chance to elaborate on her/his experience
"Ask the girl if she has anyone to talk to."
Inform users about the potential harm and consequences of rule breaking
"Social media platforms need to inform more about the consequences of sexual harassment." "Social media need to inform the public about what are the consequences of rule breaking so everyone knows"
Give users the option to report to the police
"More information on how to file a report to the police and what you can file a report for."

"Report it somewhere to the police, if it is sexual abuse or a sexual offense."

"Show pictures of the police in the interface."

7.2 Translating recommendations and feedback into prototypes

Within this section, our endeavor is to transform the recommendations and innovative ideas into tangible and feasible design proposals. To facilitate comprehension and execution by technology company product teams, we have chosen to employ two highly accessible and effective communication tools: personas and interactive wireframe prototypes.

7.2.1 Personas of online sexual harassment victims

Personas are a communication tool for orienting design and development teams to the user experience. Idoughi et al. (2012) proposed a theoretical design framework for service-oriented interactive systems integrating the concept of persona. In this report, we create the following personas (See Figure 20) based on the survey data from multiple sources (see section 4.6). These personas prove invaluable not only for social media product teams but also for researchers who aim to create intervention programs designed to support victims of online sexual harassment.



Susie

Susie is a high school student (14-18 year old). Her friend tells her that her intimate picture was shared by someone on social media. She feels embarrassed and ashamed.

She wants to remove the picture from social media, report the perpetrator, and let him no longer be able to do this to her or other girls.



Amanda

Amanda is a college student (18-28 year old). She loves sharing life on social media. She usually receives unwanted intimacy messages from strangers. She feels disgusted and annoyed.

She wants to punish the harasser, let him no longer be able to do this to her or other girls.



Iris

Iris is a young women (18-30 year old). She is an immigrant and she uses social media to connect with her community and share her life. She sometimes receives humiliating comments from strangers. She feels being targeted because of her identity and culture background.

She wants justice - online communities and society to stand by her side.



Kristina

Kristina is a junior journalist (22-30 year old). She uses social media to publish news and comments. She sometimes experiences trolling because of the news or opinions she shared. Those comments make her feel anxious and depressed about those comments.

She wants those comments to be removed immediately, and she wants support from other online users.



Billie

Billie is part of the LGBTQ+ community. They uses social media to connect with their friends. They sometimes receives messages with a negative comment about their gender or sexual orientation that made them uncomfortable.

They wants those comments to be removed immediately, and they wants support from others.



Bob

Bob is a student (14-28 year old). He sometimes receives harmful messages that include humiliating comments, suggesting that he looks and behaves like a girl. He is angry and feels powerless.

He wants to report the harasser, and let him/her no longer be able to bother him again.

Figure 20. Personas of online sexual harassment victims. They are also the potential users of the online reporting system.

7.2.2 Interactive prototypes

Based on the recommendations listed in section 7, and ideas listed in section 7.1, we created the following clickable wireframe prototypes. This type of prototype is commonly used in the ideation stage of product development (Babich, 2017). We applied communication theories in the design of on-screen messages. The overall design of the reporting system is part of our ongoing research as well.

7.2.2.1 Prototype 1 – 'We support you' user reporting system

We present the 'We Support You' user reporting system (depicted in Figure 21) as an innovative approach aimed at elevating the overall user reporting experience. This system operates on three key principles:

- Providing Informative Guidelines: Equipping users with comprehensive guidance.
- Offering Emotional and Informational Support: Extending empathy and active support.
- Enhancing User Trust: Fostering a sense of trust in the platform.

When a user utilizes the 'We Support You' system to report sexual harassment content, the user flow unfolds as detailed in Figure 21:

Welcome Page: Initiating the process with an on-screen message that conveys empathy for the user's experience, underscores the platform's commitment to addressing each report seriously, offers evidence of active content moderation (potentially bolstering reporting efficacy), and provides quick access to local authorities through an 'SOS' button in emergencies.

Select a Problem Page: Users are guided through the process with assurances of report privacy and the presentation of three distinct online sexual harassment categories, each accompanied by examples.

Explain Page: This page communicates the anticipated timeline for platform actions in response to the report, outlines possible outcomes of the reporting process (such as warnings, content removal, temporary or permanent account suspension), and includes an illustrative message representing the user's chosen harassment category.

User Complaint Page: Here, users have the option to share their personal experiences and select the emotions they are feeling. This serves a dual purpose: enhancing user trust by showing that the system cares about their experiences and emotions and providing content moderators or automated systems with contextual information to improve report understanding.

Thank You Page: Expressing gratitude for the user's courage to report, this page offers non-judgmental and compassionate responses to alleviate any feelings of shame. It provides concrete information about the ongoing report status and the platform's next steps. Users are encouraged to take protective measures (e.g., blocking or restricting the offending party) directly from this page.

External Support Info Page: Encouraging users to seek help and support from real-life professionals, family, and friends, this page lists optional 24/7 local helplines offering mental health counseling and legal advice.

Welcome to report

I'm so sorry you had to experience that 😞. You're not alone, let us help you now 🤝.

We take user reports seriously. In the last 24 hours, we have taken down XXX accounts, XXX harmful content.

Call local police if there is immediate danger 🚔 

Start report

No worry, tell us what happened
We won't let others know

I'm being...

Humiliated ☐

See Example

Harassed ☐

See Example

Coerced ☐

See Example

Next

No worry, tell us what happened
We won't let others know

I'm being...

Humiliated ☐

Bltch sit your ugly a\$\$ down stay out of barbz business if you can't take a joke

Harassed ☐

See Example

Coerced ☐

See Example

Next

If we understand correctly, you want to make a report for xxx behavior

xxx behavior is not allowed in our community. We will evaluate the behavior based on our community standard within xx working days, then take one of the below actions:

- warn the person that his/her message/content is inappropriate
- remove the harmful content
- suspend the account for xx time
- permanently suspend the account

[View our entire community standard](#)

Yes, continue

No, select another

We are here to listen

Tell us more (optional)

If you want, you can tell us more what happened ...

How do you feel right now? (optional)

- ☐  Extremely angry, I want to fight back!
- ☐  Angry, how can he/she do this?!
- ☐  Little depressed
- ☐  Very depressed, it is out of my control
- ☐  This happens a lot, I don't feel anything
- ☐  Not a big deal, it is not my fault

Submit



Thanks for helping making us a better place for everyone!

We know it must have taken tremendous courage to report this. You didn't deserve that, and you deserve support now!

Now

Your report is in queue. Meanwhile, we'll hide the content from public.

Next

It'll take a few days for us to review your report. We'll notify you when the result is ready.

Recommendations

Block xxx

You will then never see any content, messages, or notifications from xxx.

Restrict xxx

Remove xxx's comment from your timeline without blocking.

Next

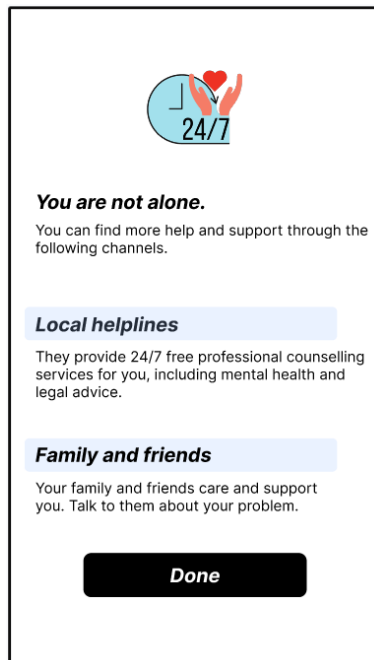


Figure 21. 'We support you' user reporting system. Picture 1 – Welcome page. Picture 2-3 Select a problem page. Picture 4 – Explain page. Picture 5 – User complaint page. Picture 6 – Thank you page. Picture 7 – External support info page.

7.2.2.2 Prototype 2 – 'Tellme' chatbot user reporting system

As an alternative to Prototype 1, we present the 'Tellme' chatbot user reporting system. This approach leverages the advantages of chatbot interaction, offering personalized attention to users' inquiries and requests, thereby facilitating a more natural and user-guided experience (Branley-Bell et al., 2023; Zarouali et al., 2018). We anticipate that the 'Tellme' chatbot reporting system can enhance the user reporting experience in several ways:

Naturalistic Interaction: The chatbot offers a more intuitive and conversational interaction compared to traditional form-filling methods.

Immediate Feedback and Human Interaction: Users receive prompt feedback and a sense of human-like interaction.

Enhanced User Satisfaction: Overall, the chatbot system aims to elevate user satisfaction with the reporting process.

While the conversation content aligns with Prototype 1, 'Tellme' distinguishes itself by offering a human-like conversational style. When a user reports sexual harassment content using the 'Tellme' chatbot user reporting system, the user flow is as shown in Figure 22.

I'm so sorry you had to experience that 😞. You're not alone, let us help you now 🤝.

We take user reports seriously. In the last 24 hours, we have taken down xxx accounts, xxx harmful content.

Call local police if there is immediate danger. 🚓 Call SOS at xxx xxx

Are you ready? Now let's start report

Start report

Type something in Send

Harassed (intimate photos, video being shared without my consent, being asked for my photos unwillingly, receiving hyper-intimacy messages)

Coerced (threatening me into sexting or other sexual activities).

Which one you want to report?

Humiliated

Harassed

Coerced

Type something in Send

below actions:

- Warn the person that his/her message/content is inappropriate
- Remove the harmful content
- Suspend the account for xx time
- Permanently suspend the account

Here is an example of xxx behavior:
xxxxxxxxxxxxxx

Do you want to continue this report?

Yes, continue

No, select another

Learn entire rules

Type something in Send

Yes, continue

We are here to listen. If you want, you can tell us more about what happened.... It is optional.

Yes, I want to tell

No, I don't tell

Yes, I want to tell

It is a safe and non-judgemental place to talk about your problem, we will not let others know about your complain. What you want to tell?

Type something in Send

No, I don't tell

Yes, I want to tell

It is a safe and non-judgemental place to talk about your problem, we will not let others know about your complain. What you want to tell?

Someone posted a hurtful comment under my picture, I just wanted to share. I feel embarrassed now.

How you feel right now?

depressed

Type something in Send

Thanks for helping make us a better place for everyone!

We know it must have taken tremendous courage to report this. You didn't deserve that, and you deserve support now!

Now your report is in queue. Meanwhile, we'll hide the content from public.

Next, it'll take a few days for us to review your report. We'll notify you when the result is ready.

To help you improve

Type something in Send

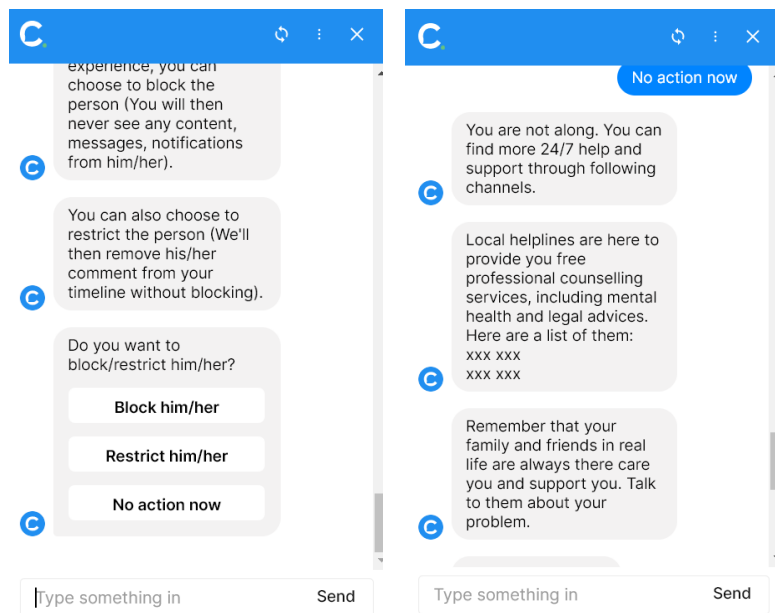


Figure 22. 'Tellme' chatbot user reporting system. Picture 1 – Welcome conversation. Picture 2 – Select problem conversation. Picture 3 – Explain behavior conversation. Picture 4 – User complaint conversation. Picture 5 – Select emotional state conversation. Picture 6 – 7 Thank you conversation. Picture 8 - External support info.

7.2.2.3 Promoting the new user reporting system

Introducing the new developments in the reporting system offers a valuable opportunity for social media platforms to cultivate trust and establish positive relationships with users and the public. This can be achieved through engaging initiatives such as live streaming campaigns aimed at involving users, journalists, activists, and researchers in the design of the new reporting system. These campaigns serve a dual purpose: they enable social media platforms to gather a wide spectrum of user and expert insights, fostering both bottom-up and professional feedback, and simultaneously enhance the platform's transparency.

Alternatively, social media platforms can create promotional videos to educate users on how to utilize the new reporting system. As part of our report, we have produced two video demonstrations showcasing the proposed prototypes:

Prototype1 – ‘We support you’ reporting system

<https://watch.wave.video/we-support-you-reporting-system-TD2FGJDmV02Gi2gF>

Prototype2 – ‘Tellme’ chatbot reporting system

<https://watch.wave.video/tellme-chatbot-reporting-system-demo-AkwHzhOA0XNoGxE>

It's important to note that the prototypes presented in this report are grounded in existing reports, user feedback, scientific studies, and results from a co-design workshop. The evaluation of the design proposal is part of our ongoing research.

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